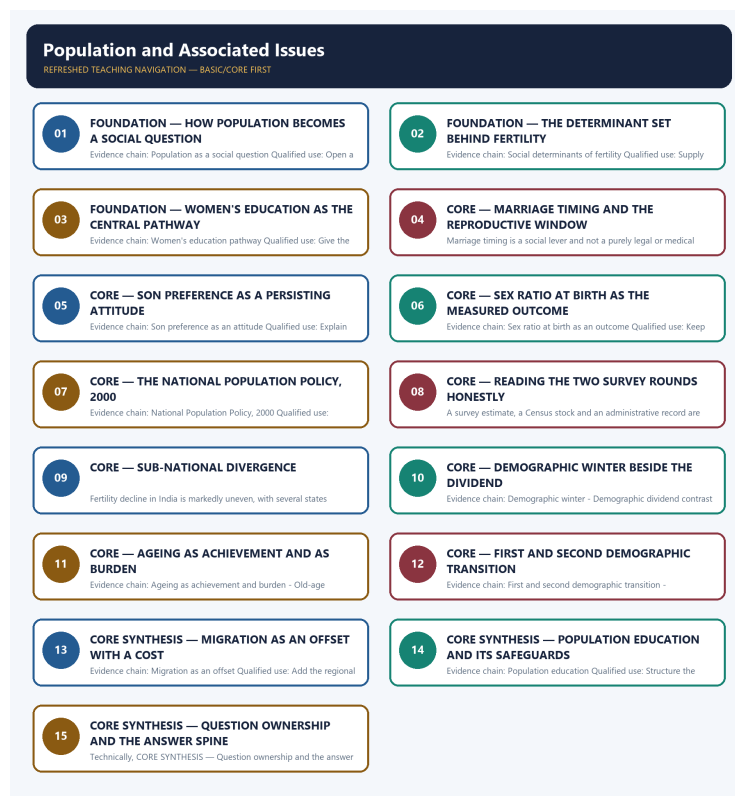


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Population and Associated Issues - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing



Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / SESSION INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Population and Associated Issues - Learner-v2 Complete Learning Session	6
SOURCE, PROGRESSION AND CURRENT-LINKAGE AUDIT	6
BASIC LEARNING SESSION	6
DEEP-REVIEW LEARNING CONTRACT	6
EVIDENCE, PYQ AND CURRENT-STATUS CONTROL	7
SESSION 1 - FOUNDATION - HOW POPULATION BECOMES A SOCIAL QUESTION	8
SESSION 2 - FOUNDATION - THE DETERMINANT SET BEHIND FERTILITY	10
SESSION 3 - FOUNDATION - WOMEN'S EDUCATION AS THE CENTRAL PATHWAY	11
SESSION 4 - CORE - MARRIAGE TIMING AND THE REPRODUCTIVE WINDOW	13
SESSION 5 - CORE - SON PREFERENCE AS A PERSISTING ATTITUDE	14
SESSION 6 - CORE - SEX RATIO AT BIRTH AS THE MEASURED OUTCOME	15
SESSION 7 - CORE - THE NATIONAL POPULATION POLICY, 2000	17
SESSION 8 - CORE - READING THE TWO SURVEY ROUNDS HONESTLY	19
SESSION 9 - CORE - SUB-NATIONAL DIVERGENCE	20
SESSION 10 - CORE - DEMOGRAPHIC WINTER BESIDE THE DIVIDEND	22
SESSION 11 - CORE - AGEING AS ACHIEVEMENT AND AS BURDEN	24
SESSION 12 - CORE - FIRST AND SECOND DEMOGRAPHIC TRANSITION	25
SESSION 13 - CORE SYNTHESIS - MIGRATION AS AN OFFSET WITH A COST	27
SESSION 14 - CORE SYNTHESIS - POPULATION EDUCATION AND ITS SAFEGUARDS	29
SESSION 15 - CORE SYNTHESIS - QUESTION OWNERSHIP AND THE ANSWER SPINE	30
INDIAN SOCIETY DEEP-REVIEW CORE CONTROL	37
BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION	37
Q1. Which statement correctly identifies Population as a social question?	37
Q2. Which chronology card should be filed under Population as a social question?	37
Q3. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Population as a social question?	38
Q4. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Population as a social question?	38
Q5. Which statement correctly identifies Social determinants of fertility?	38
Q6. Which chronology card should be filed under Social determinants of fertility?	39
Q7. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Social determinants of fertility?	39

Q8. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Social determinants of fertility?	39
Q9. Which statement correctly identifies Women's education pathway?	40
Q10. Which chronology card should be filed under Women's education pathway?	40
Q11. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Women's education pathway?	40
Q12. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Women's education pathway?	41
Q13. Which statement correctly identifies Age at marriage?	41
Q14. Which chronology card should be filed under Age at marriage?	41
Q15. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Age at marriage?	42
Q16. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Age at marriage?	42
Q17. Which statement correctly identifies Son preference as an attitude?	42
Q18. Which chronology card should be filed under Son preference as an attitude?	43
Q19. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Son preference as an attitude?	43
Q20. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Son preference as an attitude?	43
Q21. Which statement correctly identifies Sex ratio at birth as an outcome?	44
Q22. Which chronology card should be filed under Sex ratio at birth as an outcome?	44
Q23. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Sex ratio at birth as an outcome?	44
Q24. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Sex ratio at birth as an outcome?	45
Q25. Which statement correctly identifies National Population Policy, 2000?	45
Q26. Which chronology card should be filed under National Population Policy, 2000?	45
Q27. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of National Population Policy, 2000?	46
Q28. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about National Population Policy, 2000?	46
Q29. Which statement correctly identifies NFHS-5 as a historical comparator?	47
Q30. Which chronology card should be filed under NFHS-5 as a historical comparator?	47
Q31. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of NFHS-5 as a historical comparator?	47
Q32. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about NFHS-5 as a historical comparator?	48
Q33. Which statement correctly identifies NFHS-6 release and provisional status?	48
Q34. Which chronology card should be filed under NFHS-6 release and provisional status?	48
Q35. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of NFHS-6 release and provisional status?	49
Q36. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about NFHS-6 release and provisional status?	49
Q37. Which statement correctly identifies Survey is not a census stock?	49
Q38. Which chronology card should be filed under Survey is not a census stock?	50
Q39. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Survey is not a census stock?	50

Q40. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Survey is not a census stock?	50
Q41. Which statement correctly identifies Sub-national divergence?	51
Q42. Which chronology card should be filed under Sub-national divergence?	51
Q43. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Sub-national divergence?	51
Q44. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Sub-national divergence?	52
Q45. Which statement correctly identifies Demographic winter?	52
Q46. Which chronology card should be filed under Demographic winter?	52
Q47. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Demographic winter?	53
Q48. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Demographic winter?	53
Q49. Which statement correctly identifies Demographic dividend contrast?	53
Q50. Which chronology card should be filed under Demographic dividend contrast?	54
Q51. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Demographic dividend contrast?	54
Q52. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Demographic dividend contrast?	54
Q53. Which statement correctly identifies Ageing as achievement and burden?	55
Q54. Which chronology card should be filed under Ageing as achievement and burden?	55
Q55. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Ageing as achievement and burden?	55
Q56. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Ageing as achievement and burden?	56
Q57. Which statement correctly identifies Old-age dependency and family support?	56
Q58. Which chronology card should be filed under Old-age dependency and family support?	56
Q59. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Old-age dependency and family support?	57
Q60. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Old-age dependency and family support?	57
Q61. Which statement correctly identifies First and second demographic transition?	58
Q62. Which chronology card should be filed under First and second demographic transition?	58
Q63. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of First and second demographic transition?	58
Q64. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about First and second demographic transition?	59
Q65. Which statement correctly identifies Urbanisation and the cost of children?	59
Q66. Which chronology card should be filed under Urbanisation and the cost of children?	60
Q67. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Urbanisation and the cost of children?	60
Q68. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Urbanisation and the cost of children?	61
Q69. Which statement correctly identifies Migration as an offset?	61
Q70. Which chronology card should be filed under Migration as an offset?	61
Q71. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Migration as an offset?	62

Q72. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Migration as an offset?	62
Q73. Which statement correctly identifies Population education?	62
Q74. Which chronology card should be filed under Population education?	63
Q75. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Population education?	63
Q76. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Population education?	64
Q77. Which statement correctly identifies Verified direct Mains demands?	64
Q78. Which chronology card should be filed under Verified direct Mains demands?	65
Q79. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Verified direct Mains demands?	65
Q80. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Verified direct Mains demands?	66
PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE	66
VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT	66
OWNER PYQ LEDGER EXTRACTS	67
PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2019 GS-I Q9	68
PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2021 GS-I Q18	70
PYQ DEMAND CARD 3 - 2024 GS-I Q7	71
ORIGINAL MAINS 1 - 10 MARKS	73
ORIGINAL MAINS 2 - 10 MARKS	75
ORIGINAL MAINS 3 - 15 MARKS	76
ORIGINAL MAINS 4 - 15 MARKS	78
ORIGINAL MAINS 5 - 20 MARKS	80
ORIGINAL MAINS 6 - 20 MARKS	81
OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER	83
CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES	88
Population and Associated Issues: RAPID CONCEPT AND EVIDENCE MAP	88
Population and Associated Issues: CLOSE-OPTION AND CAUSAL TRAPS	90
Population and Associated Issues: ANSWER-WRITING SPINE	90
Population and Associated Issues: CURRENT-LINK AND DATA BOUNDARY	90
COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM	90

Population and Associated Issues - Learner-v2 Complete Learning Session

Authoring-only generation: 2026-09-02. No PDF was rendered and no tracker or index was mutated.

SOURCE, PROGRESSION AND CURRENT-LINKAGE AUDIT

- **Generation date:** 2026-09-02.
- **Repository-first evidence:** the Basic owner is taught first and preserved in full; the Advanced owner is retained only in the optional final teaching block.
- **OCR evidence:** Repository Markdown was primary. The OCR-searchable official General Studies Paper-I question papers held under books\mains and books\more_previous_papers were used only to confirm the wording of routed Mains PYQs. No official answer key, marking scheme, page precision or unsupported quotation was imported from them.
- **Qdrant:** not used; repository Markdown and available OCR context were sufficient.
- **PYQ integrity:** Three direct General Studies Paper-I Mains demands are carried by this owner and each is recorded with its exact routing status. The 2019 Q9 demand on empowering women in relation to population growth and the 2021 Q18 demand on the objectives of population education are routed in the audited 2018-2023 Mains ledger to the Advanced owner, while the Core owner's own answer-architecture table records that Core routing supersedes those pointers, so both are answered here from the Basic spine. The locally held official question papers for 2019 and 2021 are scanned images from which reliable text cannot be extracted, so the audited ledger's neutral demand rendering is used and no verbatim wording is claimed for those two years. The 2024 Q7 demographic-winter demand is different: its ledger row names the Geography world-population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it, and that cross-owner conflict is stated openly here rather than resolved by an unsupported analytical claim. Its wording was confirmed in the locally held official 2024 General Studies Paper-I. No marking scheme, official key or model answer of the Union Public Service Commission is held locally, and none is reproduced or inferred.
- **Live-link boundary:** No additional live official item was verified for this topic on 2026-09-02. Only the dated official anchors already carried by the repository owners are used, each with its issuing body and date. The package invents no caste, tribe, demographic or agrarian statistic, no legal or constitutional claim and no policy status.
- **Fact/inference discipline:** no current-affairs item, PYQ wording, figure or quotation is invented.

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

DEEP-REVIEW LEARNING CONTRACT

Control	Binding rule for this package
Syllabus boundary	Complete Indian Society Basic/Core is answer-complete before optional Advanced depth.
Concept method	Define and distinguish the institution, identity, process, legal category and measured indicator before analysis.
Sociological method	Structure/institution -> mechanism and agency -> differentiated group/region outcome -> feedback, resistance and qualification.
Evidence method	Claim -> named Indian community/region/institution/dataset -> analysis -> source-date-status or causal qualification.
Non-homogenisation	Caste, tribe, women, religion, region and rural/urban groups retain internal class, gender, locality and historical variation.
Boundary method	Constitutional right, statutory mandate, executive scheme, implementation and lived social outcome remain distinct.
Practice contract	Every solved item has demand decoding, a detailed examiner-grade model, executable timed/compression plan, marks rationale and answer-specific improvement.
Approval	This immutable successor remains approved: false pending explicit approval.

Canonical Basic/Core owner:

upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\Indian-Society\basic\06_Population-and-Associated-Issues.md

Canonical topic owner:

upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\Indian-Society\basic\06_Population-and-Associated-Issues.md

Optional Advanced owner:

upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\Indian-Society\advanced\06_Population-and-Associated-Issues.md

Official syllabus mapping:

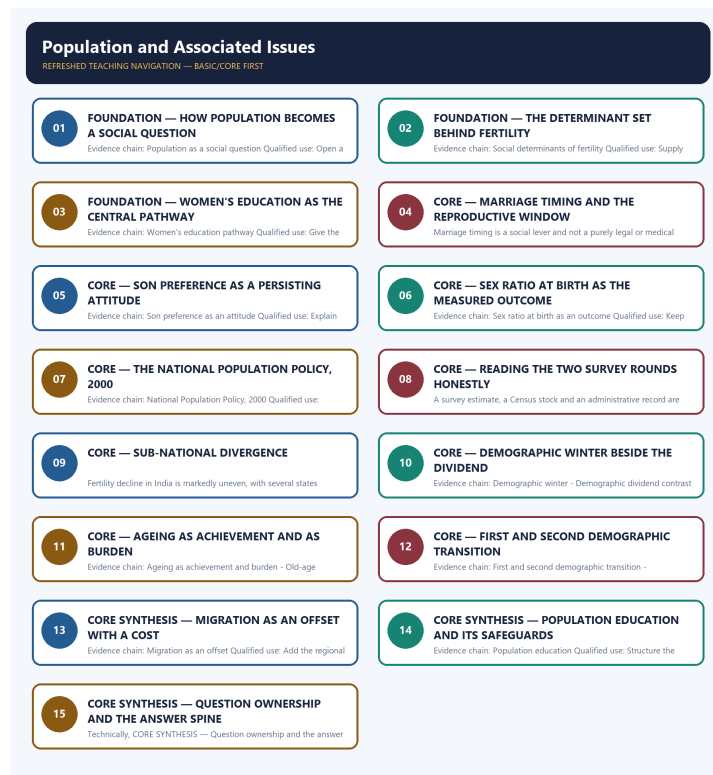
upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\Indian-Society\OFFICIAL-UPSC-SYLLABUS-MAPPING.md

EVIDENCE, PYQ AND CURRENT-STATUS CONTROL

- **Definition discipline:** close concepts and legal-administrative categories share a comparison axis and are never treated as synonyms.
- **Mechanism discipline:** correlation, temporal sequence and aggregate association do not establish causation; identify institutions, incentives, norms, power and agency.
- **Historical discipline:** colonial, constitutional, developmental, liberalisation and contemporary phases are separated without a linear tradition-to-modernity story.
- **Intersectional discipline:** overlapping caste, tribe, class, gender, religion, disability, region and life-course positions are analysed without creating a single homogeneous category.
- **India discipline:** use named communities, movements, institutions, cities, states and regional contrasts without stereotyping or treating one case as nationally representative.
- **Data discipline:** Census 2011, NFHS, PLFS, SRS, Agriculture Census, MPI and scheme claims retain source, reference period, release date, coverage and provisional/final status.
- **PYQ discipline:** repository routing ledgers and locally held papers control wording and metadata; reconstructed wording and unavailable official keys remain labelled.
- **Current-status note, rechecked 2026-09-02:** No additional live official item was verified for this topic on 2026-09-02. Only the dated official anchors already carried by the repository owners are used, each with its issuing body and date. The package invents no caste, tribe, demographic or agrarian statistic, no legal or constitutional claim and no policy status.

Live/official context sources recorded by the predecessor generation:

- No volatile live claim is necessary for the static sociological core.



Refreshed teaching navigation

Distinct embedded teaching-navigation image. The separate continuous Cārvāka-style flowchart package remains an independent at-a-glance artifact.

SESSION 1 - FOUNDATION - HOW POPULATION BECOMES A SOCIAL QUESTION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Population as a social question Qualified use: Open a population answer with social mechanisms rather than a model recital.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- FOUNDATION
- How population becomes a social question
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Population change
- Population

How to use them: Frame the answer through FOUNDATION; define How population becomes a social question, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use Population change for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

HOW POPULATION BECOMES A SOCIAL QUESTION

01. Population as a social question

BOUNDARY -> The stage-based transition model belongs to Geography and must not be re-derived in a Society answer.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- The stage-based transition model belongs to Geography and must not be re-derived in a Society answer.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact unit, named scholar, official category, dated statistic or legal boundary attached to How population becomes a social question.
- **Mains:** Open a population answer with social mechanisms rather than a model recital.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Population as a social question
- **Qualified use:** Open a population answer with social mechanisms rather than a model recital.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - FOUNDATION - HOW POPULATION BECOMES A SOCIAL QUESTION

START / CONCEPT: FOUNDATION - How population becomes a social question

|

v

EXACT TERMS: FOUNDATION • How population becomes a social question • Evidence chain • Qualified use
• Population change • Population

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: Population as a social question Qualified use: Open a population answer with social mechanisms rather than a model recital.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The stage-based transition model belongs to Geography and must not be re-derived in a Society answer.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling...

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived.

SESSION 2 - FOUNDATION - THE DETERMINANT SET BEHIND FERTILITY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Social determinants of fertility Qualified use: Supply the interacting determinant set that a discuss directive rewards.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- FOUNDATION
- The determinant set behind fertility
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Social determinants of fertility
- Social

How to use them: Frame the answer through FOUNDATION; define The determinant set behind fertility, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use Social determinants of fertility for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE DETERMINANT SET BEHIND FERTILITY

01. Social determinants of fertility

BOUNDARY -> Determinants interact, so none of them may be promoted to sole cause of a fertility outcome.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Determinants interact, so none of them may be promoted to sole cause of a fertility outcome.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact unit, named scholar, official category, dated statistic or legal boundary attached to The determinant set behind fertility.
- **Mains:** Supply the interacting determinant set that a discuss directive rewards.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Social determinants of fertility
- **Qualified use:** Supply the interacting determinant set that a discuss directive rewards.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - FOUNDATION - THE DETERMINANT SET BEHIND FERTILITY

START / CONCEPT: FOUNDATION - The determinant set behind fertility

|

v

EXACT TERMS: FOUNDATION · The determinant set behind fertility · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Social determinants of fertility · Social

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Determinants interact, so none of them may be promoted to sole cause of a fertility outcome.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Evidence chain: Social determinants of fertility Qualified use: Supply the interacting determinant set that a discuss directive rewards.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: social determinants of fertility Qualified use.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome.

SESSION 3 - FOUNDATION - WOMEN'S EDUCATION AS THE CENTRAL PATHWAY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Women's education pathway Qualified use: Give the strongest single social pathway without overstating it as a single cause.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **FOUNDATION**
- **Women's education as the central pathway**
- **Evidence chain**
- **Qualified use**
- **Women's educational attainment**
- **Women's**

How to use them: Frame the answer through FOUNDATION; define Women's education as the central pathway, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use Women's educational attainment for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

WOMEN'S EDUCATION AS THE CENTRAL PATHWAY

01. Women's education pathway

BOUNDARY -> Educational attainment works in interaction with service access, income, norms and state context.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Educational attainment works in interaction with service access, income, norms and state context.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact unit, named scholar, official category, dated statistic or legal boundary attached to Women's education as the central pathway.
- **Mains:** Give the strongest single social pathway without overstating it as a single cause.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Women's education pathway
- **Qualified use:** Give the strongest single social pathway without overstating it as a single cause.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - FOUNDATION - WOMEN'S EDUCATION AS THE CENTRAL PATHWAY

START / CONCEPT: FOUNDATION - Women's education as the central pathway

|
v

EXACT TERMS: FOUNDATION · Women's education as the central pathway · Evidence chain · Qualified use
· Women's educational attainment · Women's

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: Women's education pathway Qualified use: Give the strongest single social pathway without overstating it as a single cause.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The resulting consequence is that women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception...

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception...

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context.

SESSION 4 - CORE - MARRIAGE TIMING AND THE REPRODUCTIVE WINDOW

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable.

Technical definition: Marriage timing is a social lever and not a purely legal or medical variable.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Marriage timing
- the reproductive window
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Marriage
- Add

How to use them: Frame the answer through Marriage timing; define the reproductive window, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use Marriage for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

MARRIAGE TIMING AND THE REPRODUCTIVE WINDOW

01. Age at marriage

BOUNDARY -> Marriage timing is a social lever and not a purely legal or medical variable.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Marriage timing is a social lever and not a purely legal or medical variable.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact unit, named scholar, official category, dated statistic or legal boundary attached to Marriage timing and the reproductive window.
- **Mains:** Add the mechanism that connects fertility to maternal and child health.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Age at marriage
- **Qualified use:** Add the mechanism that connects fertility to maternal and child health.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - MARRIAGE TIMING AND THE REPRODUCTIVE WINDOW

START / CONCEPT: CORE - Marriage timing and the reproductive window
|
v
EXACT TERMS: Marriage timing · the reproductive window · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Marriage
· Add
|
v
MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: Age at marriage Qualified use: Add the mechanism that connects fertility to maternal and child health.
|
v
CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Marriage timing is a social lever and not a purely legal or medical variable.
|
v
UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: add the mechanism that connects fertility to maternal and child health.
|
v
ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable.

SESSION 5 - CORE - SON PREFERENCE AS A PERSISTING ATTITUDE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its overall desired family size.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Son preference as an attitude Qualified use: Explain why fertility decline alone does not close the gender question.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: Son preference as an attitude Qualified use: Explain why fertility decline alone does not close the gender question.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Son preference as a persisting attitude
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Son preference
- Son
- Attitudes

How to use them: Frame the answer through Son preference as a persisting attitude; define Evidence chain, connect Qualified use with Son preference to explain the mechanism, and use Son for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

SON PREFERENCE AS A PERSISTING ATTITUDE

01. Son preference as an attitude

BOUNDARY -> Attitudes can persist after desired family size has already fallen.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its overall desired family size.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its overall desired family size.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Attitudes can persist after desired family size has already fallen.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact unit, named scholar, official category, dated statistic or legal boundary attached to Son preference as a persisting attitude.
- **Mains:** Explain why fertility decline alone does not close the gender question.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Son preference as an attitude
- **Qualified use:** Explain why fertility decline alone does not close the gender question.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - SON PREFERENCE AS A PERSISTING ATTITUDE

START / CONCEPT: CORE - Son preference as a persisting attitude

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Son preference as a persisting attitude · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Son preference · Son · Attitudes

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its overall desired family size.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Mains: Explain why fertility decline alone does not close the gender question.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: attitudes can persist after desired family size has already fallen.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: Son preference as an attitude Qualified use: Explain why fertility decline alone does not close the gender question.

SESSION 6 - CORE - SEX RATIO AT BIRTH AS THE MEASURED OUTCOME

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Sex ratio at birth as an outcome Qualified use: Keep the attitude and its metric separate inside one paragraph.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **Sex ratio at birth as the measured outcome**
- **Evidence chain**
- **Qualified use**
- **The sex ratio at birth**
- **India**
- **Social Justice**

How to use them: Frame the answer through Sex ratio at birth as the measured outcome; define Evidence chain, connect Qualified use with The sex ratio at birth to explain the mechanism, and use India for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

SEX RATIO AT BIRTH AS THE MEASURED OUTCOME

01. Sex ratio at birth as an outcome

BOUNDARY -> The legal response to sex selection is owned by Social Justice and Polity, not restated here.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- The legal response to sex selection is owned by Social Justice and Polity, not restated here.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact unit, named scholar, official category, dated statistic or legal boundary attached to Sex ratio at birth as the measured outcome.
- **Mains:** Keep the attitude and its metric separate inside one paragraph.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Sex ratio at birth as an outcome
- **Qualified use:** Keep the attitude and its metric separate inside one paragraph.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - SEX RATIO AT BIRTH AS THE MEASURED OUTCOME

START / CONCEPT: CORE - Sex ratio at birth as the measured outcome

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Sex ratio at birth as the measured outcome · Evidence chain · Qualified use · The sex ratio at birth · India · Social Justice

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: Sex ratio at birth as an outcome Qualified use: Keep the attitude and its metric separate inside one paragraph.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The legal response to sex selection is owned by Social Justice and Polity, not restated here.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: sex ratio at birth as an outcome Qualified use.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter.

SESSION 7 - CORE - THE NATIONAL POPULATION POLICY, 2000

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: National Population Policy, 2000 Qualified use: Anchor the policy half of a population answer in one named dated document.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- The National Population Policy
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Ministry
- Health
- Family Welfare

How to use them: Frame the answer through The National Population Policy; define Evidence chain, connect Qualified use with Ministry to explain the mechanism, and use Health for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE NATIONAL POPULATION POLICY, 2000

01. National Population Policy, 2000

BOUNDARY -> A stated policy objective is not an achieved outcome and never a coercive mandate.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- A stated policy objective is not an achieved outcome and never a coercive mandate.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact unit, named scholar, official category, dated statistic or legal boundary attached to The National Population Policy, 2000.
- **Mains:** Anchor the policy half of a population answer in one named dated document.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** National Population Policy, 2000
- **Qualified use:** Anchor the policy half of a population answer in one named dated document.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - THE NATIONAL POPULATION POLICY, 2000

START / CONCEPT: CORE - The National Population Policy, 2000

|

v

EXACT TERMS: The National Population Policy · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Ministry · Health · Family Welfare

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: National Population Policy, 2000 Qualified use: Anchor the policy half of a population answer in one named dated document.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: A stated policy objective is not an achieved outcome and never a coercive mandate.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set...

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target.

SESSION 8 - CORE - READING THE TWO SURVEY ROUNDS HONESTLY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet.

Technical definition: A survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative record are three different kinds of evidence.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Reading the two survey rounds honestly
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- The National Family Health Survey
- 2019-21
- 2023-24

How to use them: Frame the answer through Reading the two survey rounds honestly; define Evidence chain, connect Qualified use with The National Family Health Survey to explain the mechanism, and use 2019-21 for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

READING THE TWO SURVEY ROUNDS HONESTLY

01. NFHS-5 as a historical comparator

|

v

02. NFHS-6 release and provisional status

|

v

03. Survey is not a census stock

BOUNDARY -> A survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative record are three different kinds of evidence.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value. The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet. A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value.

- The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet.
- A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- A survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative record are three different kinds of evidence.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact unit, named scholar, official category, dated statistic or legal boundary attached to Reading the two survey rounds honestly.
- **Mains:** Cite a dated fertility anchor without converting it into a current uniform figure.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** NFHS-5 as a historical comparator -> NFHS-6 release and provisional status -> Survey is not a census stock
- **Qualified use:** Cite a dated fertility anchor without converting it into a current uniform figure.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - READING THE TWO SURVEY ROUNDS HONESTLY

START / CONCEPT: CORE - Reading the two survey rounds honestly

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Reading the two survey rounds honestly · Evidence chain · Qualified use · The National Family Health Survey · 2019-21 · 2023-24

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Evidence chain: NFHS-5 as a historical comparator - NFHS-6 release and provisional status - Survey is not a census stock Qualified use: Cite a dated fertility anchor without converting it into a current uniform figure.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: a survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative record are three different kinds...

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value.

SESSION 9 - CORE - SUB-NATIONAL DIVERGENCE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Evidence chain: Sub-national divergence Qualified use: Convert an aggregate figure into the disaggregation the examiner is testing.

Technical definition: Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: Sub-national divergence Qualified use: Convert an aggregate figure into the disaggregation the examiner is testing.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Sub-national divergence
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Fertility decline in India
- Fertility
- India

How to use them: Frame the answer through Sub-national divergence; define Evidence chain, connect Qualified use with Fertility decline in India to explain the mechanism, and use Fertility for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

SUB-NATIONAL DIVERGENCE

01. Sub-national divergence

BOUNDARY -> A national aggregate is a weighted summary of states in different phases, not a description of any state.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- A national aggregate is a weighted summary of states in different phases, not a description of any state.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact unit, named scholar, official category, dated statistic or legal boundary attached to Sub-national divergence.
- **Mains:** Convert an aggregate figure into the disaggregation the examiner is testing.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Sub-national divergence
- **Qualified use:** Convert an aggregate figure into the disaggregation the examiner is testing.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - SUB-NATIONAL DIVERGENCE

START / CONCEPT: CORE - Sub-national divergence

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Sub-national divergence · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Fertility decline in India
· Fertility · India

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Mains: Convert an aggregate figure into the disaggregation the examiner is testing.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: A national aggregate is a weighted summary of states in different phases, not a description of any state.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: Sub-national divergence Qualified use: Convert an aggregate figure into the disaggregation the examiner is testing.

SESSION 10 - CORE - DEMOGRAPHIC WINTER BESIDE THE DIVIDEND

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Demographic winter - Demographic dividend contrast Qualified use: Answer an elaborate directive with a graded rather than a yes-or-no verdict.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Demographic winter beside the dividend
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Demographic winter
- Demographic
- The demographic dividend

How to use them: Frame the answer through Demographic winter beside the dividend; define Evidence chain, connect Qualified use with Demographic winter to explain the mechanism, and use Demographic for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

DEMOGRAPHIC WINTER BESIDE THE DIVIDEND

01. Demographic winter

|

v

02. Demographic dividend contrast

BOUNDARY -> Both are conditional phases, so neither may be attached to a whole country from one average.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average. The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average.
- The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Both are conditional phases, so neither may be attached to a whole country from one average.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact unit, named scholar, official category, dated statistic or legal boundary attached to Demographic winter beside the dividend.
- **Mains:** Answer an elaborate directive with a graded rather than a yes-or-no verdict.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Demographic winter -> Demographic dividend contrast
- **Qualified use:** Answer an elaborate directive with a graded rather than a yes-or-no verdict.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - DEMOGRAPHIC WINTER BESIDE THE DIVIDEND

START / CONCEPT: CORE - Demographic winter beside the dividend

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Demographic winter beside the dividend · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Demographic winter · Demographic · The demographic dividend

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: Demographic winter - Demographic dividend contrast Qualified use: Answer an elaborate directive with a graded rather than a yes-or-no verdict.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: both are conditional phases, so neither may be attached to a whole country from...

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window.

SESSION 11 - CORE - AGEING AS ACHIEVEMENT AND AS BURDEN

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Ageing as achievement and burden - Old-age dependency and family support
Qualified use: Hold both framings of ageing together instead of choosing one.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: Ageing as achievement and burden - Old-age dependency and family support
Qualified use: Hold both framings of ageing together instead of choosing one.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Ageing as achievement
- as burden
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Population
- India

How to use them: Frame the answer through Ageing as achievement; define as burden, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use Population for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

AGEING AS ACHIEVEMENT AND AS BURDEN

01. Ageing as achievement and burden

|

v

02. Old-age dependency and family support

BOUNDARY -> Formal old-age social-security scheme detail is owned by Social Justice and is cross-linked here.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

Population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age support and workforce-composition challenges, so a competent answer holds both framings together instead of choosing one. A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- Population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age support and workforce-composition challenges, so a competent answer holds both framings together instead of choosing one.
- A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Formal old-age social-security scheme detail is owned by Social Justice and is cross-linked here.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact unit, named scholar, official category, dated statistic or legal boundary attached to Ageing as achievement and as burden.

- **Mains:** Hold both framings of ageing together instead of choosing one.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Ageing as achievement and burden -> Old-age dependency and family support
- **Qualified use:** Hold both framings of ageing together instead of choosing one.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - AGEING AS ACHIEVEMENT AND AS BURDEN

START / CONCEPT: CORE - Ageing as achievement and as burden

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Ageing as achievement · as burden · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Population · India

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Formal old-age social-security scheme detail is owned by Social Justice and is cross-linked here.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age...

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: Ageing as achievement and burden - Old-age dependency and family support Qualified use: Hold both framings of ageing together instead of choosing one.

SESSION 12 - CORE - FIRST AND SECOND DEMOGRAPHIC TRANSITION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: First and second demographic transition - Urbanisation and the cost of children
Qualified use: Explain below-replacement fertility beyond material necessity with a labelled framework.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: First and second demographic transition - Urbanisation and the cost of children
Qualified use: Explain below-replacement fertility beyond material necessity with a labelled framework.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- First
- second demographic transition
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- The first demographic transition
- European

How to use them: Frame the answer through First; define second demographic transition, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use The first demographic transition for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

FIRST AND SECOND DEMOGRAPHIC TRANSITION

01. First and second demographic transition

|
v

02. Urbanisation and the cost of children

BOUNDARY -> Second-transition theory is a European-derived lens rather than an established Indian diagnosis.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state. Urban residence raises both the direct cost of raising children through housing and schooling expenditure and the opportunity cost through foregone earnings, which is why urbanisation appears repeatedly in fertility explanations as an economic pressure operating through social decisions.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state.
- Urban residence raises both the direct cost of raising children through housing and schooling expenditure and the opportunity cost through foregone earnings, which is why urbanisation appears repeatedly in fertility explanations as an economic pressure operating through social decisions.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Second-transition theory is a European-derived lens rather than an established Indian diagnosis.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact unit, named scholar, official category, dated statistic or legal boundary attached to First and second demographic transition.
- **Mains:** Explain below-replacement fertility beyond material necessity with a labelled framework.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** First and second demographic transition -> Urbanisation and the cost of children
- **Qualified use:** Explain below-replacement fertility beyond material necessity with a labelled framework.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - FIRST AND SECOND DEMOGRAPHIC TRANSITION

START / CONCEPT: CORE - First and second demographic transition

|

v

EXACT TERMS: First · second demographic transition · Evidence chain · Qualified use · The first demographic transition · European

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Second-transition theory is a European-derived lens rather than an established Indian diagnosis.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: explain below-replacement fertility beyond material necessity with a labelled framework.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: First and second demographic transition - Urbanisation and the cost of children Qualified use: Explain below-replacement fertility beyond material necessity with a labelled framework.

SESSION 13 - CORE SYNTHESIS - MIGRATION AS AN OFFSET WITH A COST

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Migration as an offset Qualified use: Add the regional trade-off that a workforce-shrinkage answer usually omits.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- CORE SYNTHESIS
- Migration as an offset with a cost
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Internal
- Migration

How to use them: Frame the answer through CORE SYNTHESIS; define Migration as an offset with a cost, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use Internal for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

MIGRATION AS AN OFFSET WITH A COST

01. Migration as an offset

BOUNDARY -> Migration redistributes the ageing problem between regions rather than removing it.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Migration redistributes the ageing problem between regions rather than removing it.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact unit, named scholar, official category, dated statistic or legal boundary attached to Migration as an offset with a cost.
- **Mains:** Add the regional trade-off that a workforce-shrinkage answer usually omits.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Migration as an offset
- **Qualified use:** Add the regional trade-off that a workforce-shrinkage answer usually omits.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE SYNTHESIS - MIGRATION AS AN OFFSET WITH A COST

START / CONCEPT: CORE SYNTHESIS - Migration as an offset with a cost

|

v

EXACT TERMS: CORE SYNTHESIS • Migration as an offset with a cost • Evidence chain • Qualified use • Internal • Migration

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: Migration as an offset Qualified use: Add the regional trade-off that a workforce-shrinkage answer usually omits.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The resulting consequence is that internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending...

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending...

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it.

SESSION 14 - CORE SYNTHESIS - POPULATION EDUCATION AND ITS SAFEGUARDS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Population education Qualified use: Structure the objectives-and-measures demand with an anti-coercion conclusion.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- CORE SYNTHESIS
- Population education
- its safeguards
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Population

How to use them: Frame the answer through CORE SYNTHESIS; define Population education, connect its safeguards with Evidence chain to explain the mechanism, and use Qualified use for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

POPULATION EDUCATION AND ITS SAFEGUARDS

01. Population education

BOUNDARY -> Population education must build voluntary capability and never a demographic target.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Population education must build voluntary capability and never a demographic target.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact unit, named scholar, official category, dated statistic or legal boundary attached to Population education and its safeguards.
- **Mains:** Structure the objectives-and-measures demand with an anti-coercion conclusion.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Population education
- **Qualified use:** Structure the objectives-and-measures demand with an anti-coercion conclusion.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE SYNTHESIS - POPULATION EDUCATION AND ITS SAFEGUARDS

START / CONCEPT: CORE SYNTHESIS - Population education and its safeguards

|

v

EXACT TERMS: CORE SYNTHESIS · Population education · its safeguards · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Population

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: Population education Qualified use: Structure the objectives-and-measures demand with an anti-coercion conclusion.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Population education must build voluntary capability and never a demographic target.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: structure the objectives-and-measures demand with an anti-coercion conclusion.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards.

SESSION 15 - CORE SYNTHESIS - QUESTION OWNERSHIP AND THE ANSWER SPINE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Evidence chain: Verified direct Mains demands Qualified use: Assemble the population answer spine with honest question ownership.

Technical definition: Technically, CORE SYNTHESIS - Question ownership and the answer spine is analysed by relating CORE SYNTHESIS to Question ownership, then testing the relationship through the answer spine and Evidence chain.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: Verified direct Mains demands Qualified use: Assemble the population answer spine with honest question ownership.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- CORE SYNTHESIS
- Question ownership
- the answer spine
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Subject

How to use them: Frame the answer through CORE SYNTHESIS; define Question ownership, connect the answer spine with Evidence chain to explain the mechanism, and use Qualified use for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

QUESTION OWNERSHIP AND THE ANSWER SPINE

01. Verified direct Mains demands

BOUNDARY -> One routed demand names the Geography population owner while this owner's own table claims it, and the conflict is stated rather than hidden.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

Three direct General Studies Paper-I demands are carried by this owner: the 2019 demand on empowering women in relation to population growth worth 10 marks and the 2021 demand on the objectives of population education and the measures India needs worth 15 marks, both routed in the audited 2018-2023 ledger to the Advanced owner with the Core owner recording that Core routing supersedes, and the 2024 demographic-winter demand worth 10 marks whose ledger route names the Geography population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- Three direct General Studies Paper-I demands are carried by this owner: the 2019 demand on empowering women in relation to population growth worth 10 marks and the 2021 demand on the objectives of population education and the measures India needs worth 15 marks, both routed in the audited 2018-2023 ledger to the Advanced owner with the Core owner recording that Core routing supersedes, and the 2024 demographic-winter demand worth 10 marks whose ledger route names the Geography population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- One routed demand names the Geography population owner while this owner's own table claims it, and the conflict is stated rather than hidden.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact unit, named scholar, official category, dated statistic or legal boundary attached to Question ownership and the answer spine.
- **Mains:** Assemble the population answer spine with honest question ownership.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Verified direct Mains demands
- **Qualified use:** Assemble the population answer spine with honest question ownership.

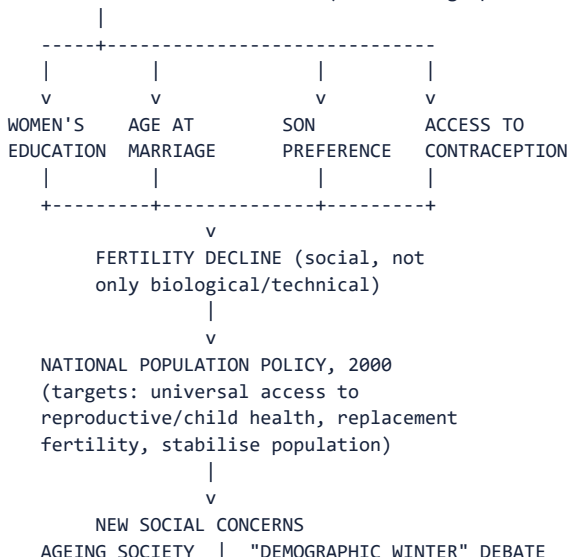
COMPLETE BASIC OWNER EVIDENCE BANK

Subject: Indian Society | **Tier:** Must-Do (foundation) | **GS Paper:** GS-I. **Core area:** Population as a social issue - social determinants of fertility, National Population Policy 2000, ageing, son preference, and the "demographic winter" debate. **Grounded in:** National Population Policy 2000 (MoHFW); NFHS-5 (2019-21; historical comparator; NFHS-6 was released 29 May 2026); audited 2024 GS-I Mains PYQ. **FACT:** = source-grounded | **ANALYSIS:** = analytical inference | **CURRENT:** = current anchor. *Companion:* advanced/06_Population-and-Associated-Issues.md.

Data-status correction (13 August 2026): NFHS-6 (2023-24) was released on 29 May 2026. NFHS-5 (2019-21) values below are historical comparators, not the latest national NFHS result. Do not quote an NFHS-6 metric unless taken directly from its released national fact sheet; neither NFHS round is a Census stock or by itself proof of causation.

1. Visual foundation

POPULATION AS A SOCIAL ISSUE (not a demographic-transition model)



Core proposition: ANALYSIS: Population change in India is a social process shaped by women's education, age at marriage, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, alongside economic and regional conditions. Fertility transition can create ageing and old-age-support concerns while maternal/child health and sub-national inequality remain important; neither a single national TFR nor “demographic winter” settles the picture.

2. Essential definitions

Concept	Exam-ready meaning
FACT: National Population Policy, 2000	India's policy framework (MoHFW) with the immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive needs, the medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level, and the long-term objective of a stable population consistent with sustainable development.
FACT: Social determinants of fertility	Non-biological factors - women's education, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference - that shape fertility decisions alongside health, income and regional context. Association does not make any one factor the sole cause.
FACT: Son preference	A social preference for male children over female children, linked historically to inheritance, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, reflected in skewed sex ratios at birth in some regions.
ANALYSIS: Demographic winter	A term describing sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support burdens.
ANALYSIS: Ageing society	A population structure with a rising proportion of elderly persons relative to the working-age population, a consequence of sustained fertility decline combined with rising life expectancy.

3. How population functions as a social issue

- 1. Education as a key determinant:** FACT: women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, contraceptive knowledge and wider life options, and is a major social pathway in fertility transition. Its effect interacts with service access, income, norms and state context.
- 2. Age at marriage:** FACT: later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, making it a central social lever alongside contraception.
- 3. Son preference and sex ratio at birth:** FACT: persistent son preference in parts of India

has produced skewed sex ratios at birth through sex-selective practices, a social (attitudinal) problem rather than a purely medical or legal one, even though legal remedies exist separately.

4. **National Population Policy 2000's tiered goals:** FACT: NPP 2000 set immediate (unmet contraceptive need), medium-term (replacement-level TFR) and long-term (stable population by 2045, aligned with sustainable development) objectives - a socially oriented, rights-based population policy rather than a coercive target-driven one.

5. **Multiple transition concerns:** ANALYSIS: where fertility is lower and life expectancy rises, ageing and old-age support become more salient; other places still face unmet health, reproductive-choice and child-development concerns. Avoid describing one national "dominant" problem.

6. **The demographic winter debate:** ANALYSIS: the 2024 PYQ's "demographic winter" question asks whether the world (and, by extension, India in its more advanced-transition states) is moving toward sustained sub-replacement fertility and population decline - the answer is regionally uneven: some Indian states already show below-replacement fertility while others remain above it.

4. Institutions and concepts

- FACT: **National Population Policy, 2000 (MoHFW):** the guiding social-policy document for fertility, health and stabilisation goals.
- ANALYSIS: **Demographic Transition Model and demographic dividend theory:** the stage-based fertility/mortality transition model and the dividend-window concept are treated in `Geography/basic/26_World-Population-and-Demographic-Transition.md` and are not re-derived here.
- ANALYSIS: **Elderly-support institutions:** family-based old-age support remains the dominant Indian model; formal old-age social-security schemes and legal maintenance provisions are treated in `Social-Justice/basic/12_Elderly-and-Senior-Citizens.md`.
- ANALYSIS: **Sex-selection prevention law:** the legal-regulatory response to son preference and skewed sex ratio at birth is a Social-Justice/Polity matter, not elaborated here.

5. Indian applications and PYQ mapping

- FACT: **2024 GS-I PYQ (10 marks, verbatim):** "What is the concept of a 'demographic winter'? Is the world moving towards such a situation? Elaborate." The expected answer: define demographic winter as sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual decline; note that several developed countries and some Indian states already show this pattern, while India in aggregate and many developing countries remain above replacement, so the world is moving toward this situation unevenly rather than uniformly, with social causes (women's education, delayed marriage, urbanisation, rising child-rearing cost) driving the shift.
- ANALYSIS: A state with a Total Fertility Rate already below replacement level illustrates localised "demographic winter" conditions coexisting with a still-younger national average.

6. Must-Know Facts for Prelims

- FACT: NFHS-5 (2019-21) reported India's Total Fertility Rate at 2.0. It is a historical comparator; the current released provisional national fact-sheet round is NFHS-6 (2023-24), not a current-year estimate.
- FACT: National Population Policy, 2000 set immediate, medium-term and long-term goals culminating in a stable population aligned with sustainable development.
- FACT: Women's education is a major social determinant associated with fertility transition, alongside marriage age, health services, income, norms and state context.
- ANALYSIS: Fertility decline is markedly uneven across states, with several southern and some northern states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain higher.
- ANALYSIS: Ageing-society concerns (rising elderly dependency) are an emerging, not yet dominant, social issue in most of India, but are already significant in early-transition states.

7. UPSC traps

- WRONG: "Demographic winter" and "demographic dividend" describe the same phenomenon. ->

Demographic winter describes sub-replacement fertility and population ageing/decline; demographic dividend describes the growth-favourable window when the working-age share is largest - they are near-opposite phases of the transition (dividend theory is Geography's territory).

- WRONG: India's fertility rate is uniformly high across all states. -> NFHS-5 reported a national TFR of 2.0 (2019-21), while state patterns varied substantially. A national survey average must not be used as a current, uniform state figure.

- WRONG: National Population Policy, 2000 set a coercive one-child or two-child national target.

-> NPP 2000 is a rights-based, tiered-objective policy focused on unmet need, replacement fertility and long-term stabilisation, not a coercive mandate.

- WRONG: Son preference is only a legal problem, addressed fully by anti-sex-selection law. ->

It is fundamentally a social-attitudinal problem (inheritance expectations, old-age support beliefs) that legal deterrence alone cannot resolve.

8. CURRENT: Current anchor

- CURRENT: NFHS-6 (2023-24) national fact sheets report a total TFR of **2.0** (urban 1.6, rural 2.1). The fact sheets label results provisional; this is a survey estimate, not a Census stock or a uniform state figure.

9. PYQ application

- FACT: **2024 GS-I (10 marks)**: define demographic winter precisely, use global population evidence for the world-level claim, and use the dated NFHS-5 TFR of 2.0 only as an Indian survey anchor while flagging sub-national variation. Conclude that movement toward it is uneven, not a single global or Indian fact.

10. Mains angles

- ANALYSIS: Always frame population questions around social determinants first, cross-linking demographic-transition theory rather than re-deriving it.
- ANALYSIS: Use NFHS-5's 2019-21 TFR of 2.0 only as a dated survey anchor; use a newer official release if one exists when writing an exam answer.
- ANALYSIS: Do not use an India-only fertility survey to prove a global demographic-winter claim.
- ANALYSIS: Distinguish demographic winter from demographic dividend explicitly whenever both terms could plausibly appear in a question.

Answer thesis: India's dated NFHS-5 national TFR of 2.0 masks substantial sub-national diversity. Population answers should connect fertility to interlocking social determinants, then balance ageing and old-age-support pressures with unfinished health, reproductive-choice and regional-equity concerns; "demographic winter" is a conditional population pattern, not a label for India as a whole.

11. Probable questions

- ANALYSIS: **Prelims**: What are the three tiers of objectives set by the National Population Policy, 2000?
- FACT: **Mains (10 marks, 2024 GS-I PYQ, verbatim)**: What is the concept of a 'demographic winter'? Is the world moving towards such a situation? Elaborate.
- ANALYSIS: **Mains (10 marks)**: Discuss the social determinants of fertility decline in India.
- ANALYSIS: **Mains (15 marks)**: Examine the social implications of India's transition toward an ageing population structure.

12. Study links

- FACT: Advanced companion: [advanced/06_Population-and-Associated-Issues.md](#).

- FACT: Geography/basic/26_World-Population-and-Demographic-Transition.md - Demographic Transition Model, indicators, pyramids and demographic-dividend theory (do not re-derive here).
- FACT: Social-Justice/basic/12_Elderly-and-Senior-Citizens.md - old-age welfare law and schemes.
- FACT: 07_Women-and-Womens-Organisations.md - women's education/agency as a fertility determinant, treated further there.

13. Answer architecture (10/15/20-mark support)

Core-only. Population questions require social mechanisms and measurement discipline; they must not turn fertility into coercion, a single national average or a geographic model recital.

13.1 Directive-to-structure map

Demand family	What is tested	Structure that scores
Elaborate demographic winter	Definition plus uneven world/state movement	define -> drivers -> uneven evidence -> consequences -> graded verdict
Discuss women's empowerment and population	Agency pathway, not population control	capability -> delayed/voluntary choices -> health -> qualification
Discuss and point out population education	Objectives, methods and rights safety	objective -> age-appropriate content -> institutions -> safeguards
Examine ageing	Achievement and support challenge	transition -> care/workforce implications -> state variation
Analyse son preference	norm versus metric	attitude -> sex ratio at birth -> social consequences -> balance

13.2 Thesis bank

- **T1: ANALYSIS:** Fertility transition is produced by agency, health, education and security; it should not be treated as a numerical-control project.
- **T2: ANALYSIS:** Demographic winter is an uneven age-structure risk, not a label that a dated national TFR can attach to India as a whole.
- **T3: ANALYSIS:** Population education works when it builds informed, voluntary capability rather than imposing demographic targets.

13.3 Mark-scaled spines

10 marks - empowering women and population growth (2019 GS-I). Start with T1. Link education, later marriage, health information, paid work/voice and voluntary contraceptive access to informed family-size choices; add son preference and uneven services as constraints. Conclude with rights-based choice, not "control".

15 marks - objectives and measures of population education (2021 GS-I). Define it as age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education. Organise objectives under health/reproductive information, gender equality and delayed marriage, small-family informed choice, and population-resource awareness. Add school/community/service delivery, the NPP 2000 frame and an anti-coercion conclusion.

20 marks - India's uneven demographic transition. Start from national versus sub-national divergence; use fertility, ageing, sex ratio at birth, migration and dependency. Explain the demographic-winter/dividend distinction, route DTM mechanics to Geography and close with state-specific care, health, skills and gender-policy needs.

13.4 Evidence bank - claim -> named evidence/example -> significance -> limitation

- **E1 - Rights-based policy.** *Claim:* population policy can be rights-oriented.

Evidence: **National Population Policy, 2000**-unmet contraceptive need, replacement fertility and long-term stabilisation objectives. *Significance:* supports an agency-based answer. *Limitation:* a policy objective is not an

outcome or a coercive mandate.

- **E2 - Historical fertility comparator.** *Claim:* a national average can show direction, not uniformity. *Evidence:* **NFHS-5 (2019-21)** reported TFR 2.0. *Significance:* a dated historical anchor for transition. *Limitation:* NFHS-6 (2023-24) is now the latest released national survey; neither survey is a Census stock or a uniform state estimate.

- **E3 - Gender mechanism.** *Claim:* gender equality matters to demographic choice. *Evidence:* women's education, marriage age, health access and voice are named social determinants in NPP/fertility analysis. *Significance:* permits causal explanation without asserting a single determinant. *Limitation:* association does not prove one factor causes every fertility outcome.

- **E4 - Family-care mechanism.** *Claim:* ageing changes social support systems. *Evidence:* **dependency ratio** and family-based elder care, cross-linked to Social Justice. *Significance:* makes ageing a social, not merely numerical, answer. *Limitation:* do not use one state's ageing pattern as a national condition.

13.5 Balance bank and verdict scaffolds

- **ANALYSIS:** Distinguish a Census stock, NFHS survey and administrative registration.

- **ANALYSIS:** Do not present NFHS-5 as current or infer NFHS-6 figures without its released fact sheet.

- **ANALYSIS:** Distinguish demographic winter from demographic dividend and son preference from sex ratio at birth.

- **Verdict:** "India's population question is an uneven capability transition: the policy task is to expand informed choice and prepare for differing regional age structures."

13.6 Direct Mains demands this Core file must answer alone

Year · Paper · Q	Demand	Core route
2019 · GS-I · Q9	Empowering women and population growth	§13.1-13.3, T1, E1-E3
2021 · GS-I · Q18	Population education objectives and measures	§13.1, §13.3, T3
2024 · GS-I · Q7	Demographic winter	§13.1, T2, E2-E4

Routing correction: Core routes supersede the older advanced/06 pointers; Geography retains the DTM/model owner, not this topic's social-demography owner.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE SYNTHESIS - QUESTION OWNERSHIP AND THE ANSWER SPINE

START / CONCEPT: CORE SYNTHESIS - Question ownership and the answer spine

|

v

EXACT TERMS: CORE SYNTHESIS · Question ownership · the answer spine · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Subject

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: NFHS-5 (2019-21) values below are historical comparators, not the latest national NFHS result.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: One routed demand names the Geography population owner while this owner's own table claims it, and the conflict is stated rather than hidden.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not quote an NFHS-6 metric unless taken directly from its released national fact sheet; neither NFHS round is a Census stock or by itself proof of causation.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: Verified direct Mains demands Qualified use: Assemble the population answer spine with honest question ownership.

INDIAN SOCIETY DEEP-REVIEW CORE CONTROL

- **Must remember:** Population analysis separates size, growth, fertility, mortality, age structure, sex composition, density, distribution, migration and human capability; demographic transition and dividend are conditional processes shaped by health, education, gender agency and employment.
- **Close distinction:** Population growth is not fertility, replacement fertility is not zero growth, density is not pressure, sex ratio at birth is not overall sex ratio, Census stock is not survey flow, and demographic dividend is an opportunity rather than an automatic bonus.
- **Evidence / interpretation limit:** Census 2011 is the latest completed census baseline as of review, while SRS, NFHS-5 and projections have different dates and methods; compare Kerala/Tamil Nadu ageing, EAG-state youth and migration destinations without causal claims from state averages alone.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Q1. Which statement correctly identifies Population as a social question?

A. Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived. B. Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context. C. Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome. D. A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable.

Answer: A. Explanation: Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q2. Which chronology card should be filed under Population as a social question?

A. Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its overall desired family size. B. Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived. C. Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context. D. A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable.

Answer: B. Explanation: Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q3. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Population as a social question?

A. The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter. B. Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its overall desired family size. C. Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived. D. A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable.

Answer: C. Explanation: Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q4. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Population as a social question?

A. The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target. B. Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its overall desired family size. C. The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter. D. Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived.

Answer: D. Explanation: Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q5. Which statement correctly identifies Social determinants of fertility?

A. Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome. B. A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable. C. Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its overall desired family size. D. Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context.

Answer: A. Explanation: Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome. The remaining options belong to different chronology,

Q6. Which chronology card should be filed under Social determinants of fertility?

A. Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its overall desired family size. B. Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome. C. A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable. D. The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter.

Answer: B. Explanation: Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q7. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Social determinants of fertility?

A. The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter. B. Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its overall desired family size. C. Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome. D. The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target.

Answer: C. Explanation: Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q8. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Social determinants of fertility?

A. The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target. B. The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter. C. The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value. D. Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome.

Answer: D. Explanation: Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q9. Which statement correctly identifies Women's education pathway?

A. Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context. B. A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable. C. Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its overall desired family size. D. The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter.

Answer: A. Explanation: Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q10. Which chronology card should be filed under Women's education pathway?

A. Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its overall desired family size. B. Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context. C. The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter. D. The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target.

Answer: B. Explanation: Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q11. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Women's education pathway?

A. The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target. B. The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter. C. Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context. D. The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a

current-year or state-uniform value.

Answer: C. Explanation: Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q12. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Women's education pathway?

A. The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target. B. The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet. C. The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value. D. Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context.

Answer: D. Explanation: Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q13. Which statement correctly identifies Age at marriage?

A. A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable. B. The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter. C. Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its overall desired family size. D. The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target.

Answer: A. Explanation: A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q14. Which chronology card should be filed under Age at marriage?

A. The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target. B. A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable. C. The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter. D. The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical

comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value.

Answer: B. Explanation: A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q15. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Age at marriage?

A. The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value. B. The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet. C. A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable. D. The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target.

Answer: C. Explanation: A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q16. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Age at marriage?

A. The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value. B. A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation. C. The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet. D. A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable.

Answer: D. Explanation: A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q17. Which statement correctly identifies Son preference as an attitude?

A. Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its overall desired family size. B. The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value. C. The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter. D. The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable

development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target.

Answer: A. Explanation: Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its overall desired family size. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q18. Which chronology card should be filed under Son preference as an attitude?

A. The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value. B. Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its overall desired family size. C. The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet. D. The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target.

Answer: B. Explanation: Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its overall desired family size. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q19. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Son preference as an attitude?

A. The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value. B. The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet. C. Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its overall desired family size. D. A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation.

Answer: C. Explanation: Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its overall desired family size. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q20. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Son preference as an attitude?

A. A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation. B. The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet. C. Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing. D. Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its

overall desired family size.

Answer: D. Explanation: Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its overall desired family size. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q21. Which statement correctly identifies Sex ratio at birth as an outcome?

A. The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter. B. The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value. C. The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target. D. The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet.

Answer: A. Explanation: The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q22. Which chronology card should be filed under Sex ratio at birth as an outcome?

A. The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet. B. The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter. C. The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value. D. A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation.

Answer: B. Explanation: The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q23. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Sex ratio at birth as an outcome?

A. The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet. B. A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation. C. The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter. D. Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population

questions are usually testing.

Answer: C. Explanation: The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q24. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Sex ratio at birth as an outcome?

A. Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average. B. Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing. C. A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation. D. The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter.

Answer: D. Explanation: The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q25. Which statement correctly identifies National Population Policy, 2000?

A. The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target. B. A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation. C. The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet. D. The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value.

Answer: A. Explanation: The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q26. Which chronology card should be filed under National Population Policy, 2000?

A. The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet. B. The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target. C. Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing. D. A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are

three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation.

Answer: B. Explanation: The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q27. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of National Population Policy, 2000?

A. Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average. B. Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing. C. The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target. D. A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation.

Answer: C. Explanation: The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q28. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about National Population Policy, 2000?

A. Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing. B. The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window. C. Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average. D. The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target.

Answer: D. Explanation: The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q29. Which statement correctly identifies NFHS-5 as a historical comparator?

A. The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value. B. The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet. C. A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation. D. Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing.

Answer: A. Explanation: The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q30. Which chronology card should be filed under NFHS-5 as a historical comparator?

A. Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing. B. The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value. C. A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation. D. Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average.

Answer: B. Explanation: The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q31. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of NFHS-5 as a historical comparator?

A. The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window. B. Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing. C. The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value. D. Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average.

Answer: C. Explanation: The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q32. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about NFHS-5 as a historical comparator?

A. The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window. B. Population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age support and workforce-composition challenges, so a competent answer holds both framings together instead of choosing one. C. Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average. D. The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value.

Answer: D. Explanation: The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q33. Which statement correctly identifies NFHS-6 release and provisional status?

A. The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet. B. Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average. C. A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation. D. Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing.

Answer: A. Explanation: The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q34. Which chronology card should be filed under NFHS-6 release and provisional status?

A. Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average. B. The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet. C. The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window. D. Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing.

Answer: B. Explanation: The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q35. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of NFHS-6 release and provisional status?

A. Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average. B. Population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age support and workforce-composition challenges, so a competent answer holds both framings together instead of choosing one. C. The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet. D. The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window.

Answer: C. Explanation: The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q36. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about NFHS-6 release and provisional status?

A. The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window. B. Population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age support and workforce-composition challenges, so a competent answer holds both framings together instead of choosing one. C. A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing. D. The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet.

Answer: D. Explanation: The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q37. Which statement correctly identifies Survey is not a census stock?

A. A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation. B. Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing. C. The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window. D. Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average.

Answer: A. Explanation: A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation. The remaining

options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q38. Which chronology card should be filed under Survey is not a census stock?

A. The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window. B. A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation. C. Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average. D. Population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age support and workforce-composition challenges, so a competent answer holds both framings together instead of choosing one.

Answer: B. Explanation: A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q39. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Survey is not a census stock?

A. A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing. B. Population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age support and workforce-composition challenges, so a competent answer holds both framings together instead of choosing one. C. A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation. D. The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window.

Answer: C. Explanation: A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q40. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Survey is not a census stock?

A. The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state. B. A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing. C. Population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age support and workforce-composition challenges, so a competent answer holds both framings together instead of choosing one. D. A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation.

Answer: D. Explanation: A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q41. Which statement correctly identifies Sub-national divergence?

A. Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing. B. Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average. C. Population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age support and workforce-composition challenges, so a competent answer holds both framings together instead of choosing one. D. The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window.

Answer: A. Explanation: Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q42. Which chronology card should be filed under Sub-national divergence?

A. Population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age support and workforce-composition challenges, so a competent answer holds both framings together instead of choosing one. B. Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing. C. The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window. D. A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing.

Answer: B. Explanation: Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q43. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Sub-national divergence?

A. Population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age support and workforce-composition challenges, so a competent answer holds both framings together instead of choosing one. B. The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state. C. Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing. D. A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing.

Answer: C. Explanation: Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q44. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Sub-national divergence?

A. The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state. B. A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing. C. Urban residence raises both the direct cost of raising children through housing and schooling expenditure and the opportunity cost through foregone earnings, which is why urbanisation appears repeatedly in fertility explanations as an economic pressure operating through social decisions. D. Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing.

Answer: D. Explanation: Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q45. Which statement correctly identifies Demographic winter?

A. Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average. B. Population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age support and workforce-composition challenges, so a competent answer holds both framings together instead of choosing one. C. A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing. D. The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window.

Answer: A. Explanation: Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q46. Which chronology card should be filed under Demographic winter?

A. Population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age support and workforce-composition challenges, so a competent answer holds both framings together instead of choosing one. B. Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average. C. A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing. D. The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state.

Answer: B. Explanation: Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q47. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Demographic winter?

A. The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state. B. Urban residence raises both the direct cost of raising children through housing and schooling expenditure and the opportunity cost through foregone earnings, which is why urbanisation appears repeatedly in fertility explanations as an economic pressure operating through social decisions. C. Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average. D. A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing.

Answer: C. Explanation: Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q48. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Demographic winter?

A. The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state. B. Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it. C. Urban residence raises both the direct cost of raising children through housing and schooling expenditure and the opportunity cost through foregone earnings, which is why urbanisation appears repeatedly in fertility explanations as an economic pressure operating through social decisions. D. Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average.

Answer: D. Explanation: Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q49. Which statement correctly identifies Demographic dividend contrast?

A. The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window. B. The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state. C. A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing. D. Population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age support and workforce-composition challenges, so a competent answer holds both framings together instead of choosing one.

Answer: A. Explanation: The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition,

and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q50. Which chronology card should be filed under Demographic dividend contrast?

A. A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing. B. The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window. C. Urban residence raises both the direct cost of raising children through housing and schooling expenditure and the opportunity cost through foregone earnings, which is why urbanisation appears repeatedly in fertility explanations as an economic pressure operating through social decisions. D. The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state.

Answer: B. Explanation: The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q51. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Demographic dividend contrast?

A. Urban residence raises both the direct cost of raising children through housing and schooling expenditure and the opportunity cost through foregone earnings, which is why urbanisation appears repeatedly in fertility explanations as an economic pressure operating through social decisions. B. Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it. C. The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window. D. The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state.

Answer: C. Explanation: The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q52. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Demographic dividend contrast?

A. Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards. B. Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it. C. Urban residence raises both the direct cost of raising children through housing and schooling expenditure and the opportunity cost through foregone earnings, which is why urbanisation appears repeatedly in fertility explanations as an economic pressure operating through social decisions. D. The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window.

Answer: D. Explanation: The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q53. Which statement correctly identifies Ageing as achievement and burden?

A. Population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age support and workforce-composition challenges, so a competent answer holds both framings together instead of choosing one. B. A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing. C. Urban residence raises both the direct cost of raising children through housing and schooling expenditure and the opportunity cost through foregone earnings, which is why urbanisation appears repeatedly in fertility explanations as an economic pressure operating through social decisions. D. The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state.

Answer: A. Explanation: Population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age support and workforce-composition challenges, so a competent answer holds both framings together instead of choosing one. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q54. Which chronology card should be filed under Ageing as achievement and burden?

A. The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state. B. Population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age support and workforce-composition challenges, so a competent answer holds both framings together instead of choosing one. C. Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it. D. Urban residence raises both the direct cost of raising children through housing and schooling expenditure and the opportunity cost through foregone earnings, which is why urbanisation appears repeatedly in fertility explanations as an economic pressure operating through social decisions.

Answer: B. Explanation: Population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age support and workforce-composition challenges, so a competent answer holds both framings together instead of choosing one. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q55. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Ageing as achievement and burden?

A. Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it. B. Urban residence raises both the direct cost of raising children through housing and schooling expenditure and the opportunity cost through foregone earnings, which is why urbanisation appears repeatedly in fertility explanations as an economic pressure operating through social decisions. C. Population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age support and workforce-composition challenges, so a competent answer holds both framings together instead of choosing one. D. Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit

anti-coercion safeguards.

Answer: C. Explanation: Population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age support and workforce-composition challenges, so a competent answer holds both framings together instead of choosing one. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q56. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Ageing as achievement and burden?

A. Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it. B. Three direct General Studies Paper-I demands are carried by this owner: the 2019 demand on empowering women in relation to population growth worth 10 marks and the 2021 demand on the objectives of population education and the measures India needs worth 15 marks, both routed in the audited 2018-2023 ledger to the Advanced owner with the Core owner recording that Core routing supersedes, and the 2024 demographic-winter demand worth 10 marks whose ledger route names the Geography population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it. C. Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards. D. Population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age support and workforce-composition challenges, so a competent answer holds both framings together instead of choosing one.

Answer: D. Explanation: Population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age support and workforce-composition challenges, so a competent answer holds both framings together instead of choosing one. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q57. Which statement correctly identifies Old-age dependency and family support?

A. A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing. B. Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it. C. The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state. D. Urban residence raises both the direct cost of raising children through housing and schooling expenditure and the opportunity cost through foregone earnings, which is why urbanisation appears repeatedly in fertility explanations as an economic pressure operating through social decisions.

Answer: A. Explanation: A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q58. Which chronology card should be filed under Old-age dependency and family support?

A. Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it. B. A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing. C. Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community

outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards. D. Urban residence raises both the direct cost of raising children through housing and schooling expenditure and the opportunity cost through foregone earnings, which is why urbanisation appears repeatedly in fertility explanations as an economic pressure operating through social decisions.

Answer: B. Explanation: A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q59. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Old-age dependency and family support?

A. Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards. B. Three direct General Studies Paper-I demands are carried by this owner: the 2019 demand on empowering women in relation to population growth worth 10 marks and the 2021 demand on the objectives of population education and the measures India needs worth 15 marks, both routed in the audited 2018-2023 ledger to the Advanced owner with the Core owner recording that Core routing supersedes, and the 2024 demographic-winter demand worth 10 marks whose ledger route names the Geography population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it. C. A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing. D. Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it.

Answer: C. Explanation: A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q60. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Old-age dependency and family support?

A. Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived. B. Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards. C. Three direct General Studies Paper-I demands are carried by this owner: the 2019 demand on empowering women in relation to population growth worth 10 marks and the 2021 demand on the objectives of population education and the measures India needs worth 15 marks, both routed in the audited 2018-2023 ledger to the Advanced owner with the Core owner recording that Core routing supersedes, and the 2024 demographic-winter demand worth 10 marks whose ledger route names the Geography population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it. D. A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing.

Answer: D. Explanation: A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q61. Which statement correctly identifies First and second demographic transition?

A. The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state. B. Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards. C. Urban residence raises both the direct cost of raising children through housing and schooling expenditure and the opportunity cost through foregone earnings, which is why urbanisation appears repeatedly in fertility explanations as an economic pressure operating through social decisions. D. Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it.

Answer: A. Explanation: The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q62. Which chronology card should be filed under First and second demographic transition?

A. Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards. B. The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state. C. Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it. D. Three direct General Studies Paper-I demands are carried by this owner: the 2019 demand on empowering women in relation to population growth worth 10 marks and the 2021 demand on the objectives of population education and the measures India needs worth 15 marks, both routed in the audited 2018-2023 ledger to the Advanced owner with the Core owner recording that Core routing supersedes, and the 2024 demographic-winter demand worth 10 marks whose ledger route names the Geography population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it.

Answer: B. Explanation: The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q63. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of First and second demographic transition?

A. Three direct General Studies Paper-I demands are carried by this owner: the 2019 demand on empowering women in relation to population growth worth 10 marks and the 2021 demand on the objectives of population education and the measures India needs worth 15 marks, both routed in the audited 2018-2023 ledger to the Advanced owner with the Core owner recording that Core routing supersedes, and the 2024 demographic-winter demand worth 10 marks whose ledger route names the Geography population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it. B. Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach

and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards. C. The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state. D. Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived.

Answer: C. Explanation: The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q64. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about First and second demographic transition?

A. Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived. B. Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome. C. Three direct General Studies Paper-I demands are carried by this owner: the 2019 demand on empowering women in relation to population growth worth 10 marks and the 2021 demand on the objectives of population education and the measures India needs worth 15 marks, both routed in the audited 2018-2023 ledger to the Advanced owner with the Core owner recording that Core routing supersedes, and the 2024 demographic-winter demand worth 10 marks whose ledger route names the Geography population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it. D. The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state.

Answer: D. Explanation: The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q65. Which statement correctly identifies Urbanisation and the cost of children?

A. Urban residence raises both the direct cost of raising children through housing and schooling expenditure and the opportunity cost through foregone earnings, which is why urbanisation appears repeatedly in fertility explanations as an economic pressure operating through social decisions. B. Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards. C. Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it. D. Three direct General Studies Paper-I demands are carried by this owner: the 2019 demand on empowering women in relation to population growth worth 10 marks and the 2021 demand on the objectives of population education and the measures India needs worth 15 marks, both routed in the audited 2018-2023 ledger to the Advanced owner with the Core owner recording that Core routing supersedes, and the 2024 demographic-winter demand worth 10 marks whose ledger route names the Geography population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it.

Answer: A. Explanation: Urban residence raises both the direct cost of raising children through housing and schooling expenditure and the opportunity cost through foregone earnings, which is why urbanisation appears repeatedly in fertility explanations as an economic pressure operating through social decisions. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q66. Which chronology card should be filed under Urbanisation and the cost of children?

A. Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived. B. Urban residence raises both the direct cost of raising children through housing and schooling expenditure and the opportunity cost through foregone earnings, which is why urbanisation appears repeatedly in fertility explanations as an economic pressure operating through social decisions. C. Three direct General Studies Paper-I demands are carried by this owner: the 2019 demand on empowering women in relation to population growth worth 10 marks and the 2021 demand on the objectives of population education and the measures India needs worth 15 marks, both routed in the audited 2018-2023 ledger to the Advanced owner with the Core owner recording that Core routing supersedes, and the 2024 demographic-winter demand worth 10 marks whose ledger route names the Geography population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it. D. Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards.

Answer: B. Explanation: Urban residence raises both the direct cost of raising children through housing and schooling expenditure and the opportunity cost through foregone earnings, which is why urbanisation appears repeatedly in fertility explanations as an economic pressure operating through social decisions. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q67. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Urbanisation and the cost of children?

A. Three direct General Studies Paper-I demands are carried by this owner: the 2019 demand on empowering women in relation to population growth worth 10 marks and the 2021 demand on the objectives of population education and the measures India needs worth 15 marks, both routed in the audited 2018-2023 ledger to the Advanced owner with the Core owner recording that Core routing supersedes, and the 2024 demographic-winter demand worth 10 marks whose ledger route names the Geography population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it. B. Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome. C. Urban residence raises both the direct cost of raising children through housing and schooling expenditure and the opportunity cost through foregone earnings, which is why urbanisation appears repeatedly in fertility explanations as an economic pressure operating through social decisions. D. Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived.

Answer: C. Explanation: Urban residence raises both the direct cost of raising children through housing and schooling expenditure and the opportunity cost through foregone earnings, which is why urbanisation appears repeatedly in fertility explanations as an economic pressure operating through social decisions. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q68. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Urbanisation and the cost of children?

A. Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context. B. Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome. C. Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived. D. Urban residence raises both the direct cost of raising children through housing and schooling expenditure and the opportunity cost through foregone earnings, which is why urbanisation appears repeatedly in fertility explanations as an economic pressure operating through social decisions.

Answer: D. Explanation: Urban residence raises both the direct cost of raising children through housing and schooling expenditure and the opportunity cost through foregone earnings, which is why urbanisation appears repeatedly in fertility explanations as an economic pressure operating through social decisions. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q69. Which statement correctly identifies Migration as an offset?

A. Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it. B. Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived. C. Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards. D. Three direct General Studies Paper-I demands are carried by this owner: the 2019 demand on empowering women in relation to population growth worth 10 marks and the 2021 demand on the objectives of population education and the measures India needs worth 15 marks, both routed in the audited 2018-2023 ledger to the Advanced owner with the Core owner recording that Core routing supersedes, and the 2024 demographic-winter demand worth 10 marks whose ledger route names the Geography population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it.

Answer: A. Explanation: Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q70. Which chronology card should be filed under Migration as an offset?

A. Three direct General Studies Paper-I demands are carried by this owner: the 2019 demand on empowering women in relation to population growth worth 10 marks and the 2021 demand on the objectives of population education and the measures India needs worth 15 marks, both routed in the audited 2018-2023 ledger to the Advanced owner with the Core owner recording that Core routing supersedes, and the 2024 demographic-winter demand worth 10 marks whose ledger route names the Geography population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it. B. Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it. C. Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived. D. Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size,

contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome.

Answer: B. Explanation: Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q71. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Migration as an offset?

A. Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived. B. Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context. C. Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it. D. Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome.

Answer: C. Explanation: Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q72. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Migration as an offset?

A. Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome. B. A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable. C. Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context. D. Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it.

Answer: D. Explanation: Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q73. Which statement correctly identifies Population education?

A. Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards. B. Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived. C. Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their

joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome. D. Three direct General Studies Paper-I demands are carried by this owner: the 2019 demand on empowering women in relation to population growth worth 10 marks and the 2021 demand on the objectives of population education and the measures India needs worth 15 marks, both routed in the audited 2018-2023 ledger to the Advanced owner with the Core owner recording that Core routing supersedes, and the 2024 demographic-winter demand worth 10 marks whose ledger route names the Geography population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it.

Answer: A. Explanation: Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q74. Which chronology card should be filed under Population education?

A. Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context. B. Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards. C. Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived. D. Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome.

Answer: B. Explanation: Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q75. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Population education?

A. Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome. B. A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable. C. Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards. D. Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context.

Answer: C. Explanation: Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards. The remaining options belong to

different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q76. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Population education?

A. Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context. B. Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its overall desired family size. C. A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable. D. Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards.

Answer: D. Explanation: Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q77. Which statement correctly identifies Verified direct Mains demands?

A. Three direct General Studies Paper-I demands are carried by this owner: the 2019 demand on empowering women in relation to population growth worth 10 marks and the 2021 demand on the objectives of population education and the measures India needs worth 15 marks, both routed in the audited 2018-2023 ledger to the Advanced owner with the Core owner recording that Core routing supersedes, and the 2024 demographic-winter demand worth 10 marks whose ledger route names the Geography population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it. B. Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived. C. Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome. D. Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context.

Answer: A. Explanation: Three direct General Studies Paper-I demands are carried by this owner: the 2019 demand on empowering women in relation to population growth worth 10 marks and the 2021 demand on the objectives of population education and the measures India needs worth 15 marks, both routed in the audited 2018-2023 ledger to the Advanced owner with the Core owner recording that Core routing supersedes, and the 2024 demographic-winter demand worth 10 marks whose ledger route names the Geography population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q78. Which chronology card should be filed under Verified direct Mains demands?

A. Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome. B. Three direct General Studies Paper-I demands are carried by this owner: the 2019 demand on empowering women in relation to population growth worth 10 marks and the 2021 demand on the objectives of population education and the measures India needs worth 15 marks, both routed in the audited 2018-2023 ledger to the Advanced owner with the Core owner recording that Core routing supersedes, and the 2024 demographic-winter demand worth 10 marks whose ledger route names the Geography population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it. C. A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable. D. Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context.

Answer: B. Explanation: Three direct General Studies Paper-I demands are carried by this owner: the 2019 demand on empowering women in relation to population growth worth 10 marks and the 2021 demand on the objectives of population education and the measures India needs worth 15 marks, both routed in the audited 2018-2023 ledger to the Advanced owner with the Core owner recording that Core routing supersedes, and the 2024 demographic-winter demand worth 10 marks whose ledger route names the Geography population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q79. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Verified direct Mains demands?

A. Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context. B. A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable. C. Three direct General Studies Paper-I demands are carried by this owner: the 2019 demand on empowering women in relation to population growth worth 10 marks and the 2021 demand on the objectives of population education and the measures India needs worth 15 marks, both routed in the audited 2018-2023 ledger to the Advanced owner with the Core owner recording that Core routing supersedes, and the 2024 demographic-winter demand worth 10 marks whose ledger route names the Geography population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it. D. Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its overall desired family size.

Answer: C. Explanation: Three direct General Studies Paper-I demands are carried by this owner: the 2019 demand on empowering women in relation to population growth worth 10 marks and the 2021 demand on the objectives of population education and the measures India needs worth 15 marks, both routed in the audited 2018-2023 ledger to the Advanced owner with the Core owner recording that Core routing supersedes, and the 2024 demographic-winter demand worth 10 marks whose ledger route names the Geography population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q80. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Verified direct Mains demands?

A. Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its overall desired family size. B. The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter. C. A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable. D. Three direct General Studies Paper-I demands are carried by this owner: the 2019 demand on empowering women in relation to population growth worth 10 marks and the 2021 demand on the objectives of population education and the measures India needs worth 15 marks, both routed in the audited 2018-2023 ledger to the Advanced owner with the Core owner recording that Core routing supersedes, and the 2024 demographic-winter demand worth 10 marks whose ledger route names the Geography population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it.

Answer: D. Explanation: Three direct General Studies Paper-I demands are carried by this owner: the 2019 demand on empowering women in relation to population growth worth 10 marks and the 2021 demand on the objectives of population education and the measures India needs worth 15 marks, both routed in the audited 2018-2023 ledger to the Advanced owner with the Core owner recording that Core routing supersedes, and the 2024 demographic-winter demand worth 10 marks whose ledger route names the Geography population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT

Three direct General Studies Paper-I Mains demands are carried by this owner and each is recorded with its exact routing status. The 2019 Q9 demand on empowering women in relation to population growth and the 2021 Q18 demand on the objectives of population education are routed in the audited 2018-2023 Mains ledger to the Advanced owner, while the Core owner's own answer-architecture table records that Core routing supersedes those pointers, so both are answered here from the Basic spine. The locally held official question papers for 2019 and 2021 are scanned images from which reliable text cannot be extracted, so the audited ledger's neutral demand rendering is used and no verbatim wording is claimed for those two years. The 2024 Q7 demographic-winter demand is different: its ledger row names the Geography world-population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it, and that cross-owner conflict is stated openly here rather than resolved by an unsupported analytical claim. Its wording was confirmed in the locally held official 2024 General Studies Paper-I. No marking scheme, official key or model answer of the Union Public Service Commission is held locally, and none is reproduced or inferred.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT", all clauses, a sociological mechanism, historical trajectory, intersectional and regional variation, named Indian evidence, constitutional/institutional boundaries and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT".

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Define the central concept and separate it from the nearest social or legal category. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Trace the historical and institutional setting instead of assuming a timeless practice. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical

scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

3. **Claim and named evidence:** Explain the norm, incentive, network, power or agency mechanism producing the outcome. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Use one named Indian community, movement, region, institution or source-dated dataset. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
5. **Claim and named evidence:** Qualify the pattern through intersectionality, regional variation, causation and implementation limits. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT".

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing the mechanism; define and state a thesis; organise five points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; compress examples before mechanisms and reserve the final minute for causation, group variation and legal-outcome limits.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains rather than lists, integrates India-centric evidence and avoids homogenisation, legalism and causal overclaim.

How to improve this answer: For "VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT", replace the weakest generalisation with one named community, region, institution, movement or source-dated dataset and state what that evidence cannot establish.

OWNER PYQ LEDGER EXTRACTS

5. Indian applications and PYQ mapping

- **FACT: 2024 GS-I PYQ (10 marks, verbatim):** "What is the concept of a 'demographic winter'?"

Is the world moving towards such a situation? Elaborate." The expected answer: define demographic winter as sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual decline; note that several developed countries and some Indian states already show this pattern, while India in aggregate and many developing countries remain above replacement, so the world is moving toward this situation unevenly rather than uniformly, with social causes (women's education, delayed marriage, urbanisation, rising child-rearing cost) driving the shift.

- **ANALYSIS:** A state with a Total Fertility Rate already below replacement level illustrates localised "demographic winter" conditions coexisting with a still-younger national average.

9. PYQ application

- **FACT: 2024 GS-I (10 marks):** define demographic winter precisely, use global population evidence for the world-level claim, and use the dated NFHS-5 TFR of 2.0 only as an Indian survey anchor while flagging sub-national variation. Conclude that movement toward it is uneven, not a single global or Indian fact.

10. PYQ-based analytical application

- **FACT: 2024 GS-I (10 marks, verbatim):** "What is the concept of a 'demographic winter'? Is the world moving towards such a situation? Elaborate." Analytical route: (a) define demographic winter precisely as sustained sub-replacement fertility with ageing and eventual decline; (b) cite the dated NFHS-5 national TFR of 2.0 as the Indian anchor while explicitly flagging sub-national divergence; (c) note several developed countries are already well into demographic-winter conditions; (d) conclude the world is moving toward this situation unevenly - some regions already there, others (with continued high fertility) still distant - driven by the same social determinants that explain ordinary fertility decline.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md.

- **Years represented:** 2019, 2021
- **Paper(s):** GS-I
- **Routed question demands:** 2

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2019	GS-I	9	Empowering women as key to controlling population growth	Discuss · 10 marks · 150 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2021	GS-I	18	Objectives of population education and measures for India	Discuss and point out · 15 marks · 250 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.

What this owner must now support

- Empowering women as key to controlling population growth
- Objectives of population education and measures for India

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2019 GS-I Q9

Demand: Audited ledger demand rendering: empowering women as key to controlling population growth. Discuss, 10 marks, 150 words.

Status: Routed in the audited 2018-2023 Mains ledger to the Advanced owner, with the Core owner recording that Core routing supersedes. The locally held official 2019 paper is a scanned image without reliable text extraction, so the ledger rendering is used and no verbatim wording is claimed.

Model solution: Reframe the demand before answering it: the examinable claim is that expanding women's capability, not administering population control, is what lowers fertility, so the answer tests a mechanism rather than endorsing a slogan. Establish the mechanism. Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, with wider knowledge and use of contraception and with a broader set of life options, and a later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window while improving maternal and child health outcomes; the qualification is that these are interacting associations operating alongside service access, income, norms and state context, so no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause. Add the policy anchor. The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare is tiered around unmet contraceptive need, replacement-level fertility and long-term stabilisation aligned with sustainable development, which shows that India's own stated framework is rights-based rather than coercive; the qualification is that a stated objective is not an achieved outcome. Show the limit of the empowerment claim. Son preference is an attitude rooted in inheritance rules and old-age support expectations and it can persist after desired family size has already fallen, so households may continue childbearing until a son is born even where women's schooling has risen, which means empowerment shifts the size decision faster than it shifts the composition decision. Close with a qualified verdict: empowerment is the most defensible route because it enlarges informed and voluntary choice and simultaneously improves health outcomes, but it must be paired with contraceptive access, marriage-timing support and work on son preference, and the outcome will remain state-graded because fertility in India is markedly uneven. Quote no state fertility value and no dependency figure that this owner does not carry.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2019 GS-I Q9", all clauses, a sociological mechanism, historical trajectory, intersectional and regional variation, named Indian evidence, constitutional/institutional boundaries and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Reframe the demand before answering it: the examinable claim is that expanding women's capability, not administering population control, is what lowers fertility, so the answer tests a mechanism rather than endorsing a slogan. Establish the mechanism. Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, with wider knowledge and use of contraception and with a broader set of life options, and a later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window while improving maternal and child health outcomes; the qualification is that these are interacting associations operating alongside service access, income, norms and state context, so no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause. Add the policy anchor. The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare is tiered around unmet contraceptive need, replacement-level fertility and long-term stabilisation aligned with sustainable development, which shows that India's own stated framework is rights-based rather than coercive; the qualification is that a stated objective is not an achieved outcome. Show the limit of the empowerment claim. Son preference is an attitude rooted in inheritance rules and old-age support expectations and it can persist after desired family size has already fallen, so households may continue childbearing until a son is born even where women's schooling has risen, which means empowerment shifts the size decision faster than it shifts the composition decision. Close with a qualified verdict: empowerment is the most defensible route because it enlarges informed and voluntary choice and simultaneously improves health outcomes, but it must be paired with contraceptive access, marriage-timing support and work on son preference, and the outcome will remain state-graded because fertility in India is markedly uneven. Quote no state fertility value and no dependency figure that this owner does not carry.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Demand: Audited ledger demand rendering: empowering women as key to controlling population growth. Discuss, 10 marks, 150 words. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication.

Qualification: State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Reframe the demand before answering it: the examinable claim is that expanding women's capability, not administering population control, is what lowers fertility, so the answer tests a mechanism rather than endorsing a slogan. Establish the mechanism. Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, with wider knowledge and use of contraception and with a broader set of life options, and a later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window while improving maternal and child health outcomes; the qualification is that these are interacting associations operating alongside service access, income, norms and state context, so no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause. Add the policy anchor. The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare is tiered around unmet contraceptive need, replacement-level fertility and long-term stabilisation aligned with sustainable development, which shows that India's own stated framework is rights-based rather than coercive; the qualification is that a stated objective is not an achieved outcome. Show the limit of the empowerment claim. Son preference is an attitude rooted in inheritance rules and old-age support expectations and it can persist after desired family size has already fallen, so households may continue childbearing until a son is born even where women's schooling has risen, which means empowerment shifts the size decision faster than it shifts the composition decision. Close with a qualified verdict: empowerment is the most defensible route because it enlarges informed and voluntary choice and simultaneously improves health outcomes, but it must be paired with contraceptive access, marriage-timing support and work on son preference, and the outcome will remain state-graded because fertility in India is markedly uneven. Quote no state fertility value and no dependency figure that this owner does not carry.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing the mechanism; define and state a thesis; organise five points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; compress examples before mechanisms and reserve the final minute for causation, group variation and legal-outcome limits.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains rather than lists, integrates India-centric evidence and avoids homogenisation, legalism and causal overclaim.

How to improve this answer: For “PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2019 GS-I Q9”, replace the weakest generalisation with one named community, region, institution, movement or source-dated dataset and state what that evidence cannot establish.

PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2021 GS-I Q18

Demand: Audited ledger demand rendering: objectives of population education and the measures India needs. Discuss and point out, 15 marks, 250 words.

Status: Routed in the audited 2018-2023 Mains ledger to the Advanced owner, with the Core owner recording that Core routing supersedes. The locally held official 2021 paper is a scanned image without reliable text extraction, so the ledger rendering is used and no verbatim wording is claimed.

Model solution: Define the subject precisely at the start: population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education about population processes and their social consequences, and it is not a persuasion campaign attached to a numerical target. Group the objectives so that the discuss half of the directive is visibly organised. First, reproductive and health information that allows informed decisions about marriage timing, spacing and maternal and child health. Second, gender equality and delayed marriage, because a later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and improves maternal and child outcomes while women's educational attainment widens life options. Third, informed and voluntary family-size choice framed as capability rather than compliance. Fourth, awareness of the relationship between population, resources and services so that pressure on schooling, housing and health provision is understood rather than moralised. Then point out the measures, which is the second half of the directive and where most answers thin out. Deliver the content through school curricula at age-appropriate stages, through community outreach that reaches out-of-school adolescents, and through frontline health services so that information and access arrive together rather than separately. Locate the whole design inside the National Population Policy, 2000 frame of unmet contraceptive need, replacement-level fertility and long-term stabilisation aligned with sustainable development, and attach explicit anti-coercion safeguards so the programme cannot slide into target-setting. Qualify the recommendation honestly. Fertility in India is markedly uneven across states, so identical content will meet very different conditions, and the National Family Health Survey rounds are survey estimates rather than Census stocks, so they may indicate direction without supplying a state-uniform target. Conclude that population education succeeds when it expands informed capability and fails the moment it becomes demographic instruction.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2021 GS-I Q18”, all clauses, a sociological mechanism, historical trajectory, intersectional and regional variation, named Indian evidence, constitutional/institutional boundaries and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Define the subject precisely at the start: population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education about population processes and their social consequences, and it is not a persuasion campaign attached to a numerical target. Group the objectives so that the discuss half of the directive is visibly organised. First, reproductive and health information that allows informed decisions about marriage timing, spacing and maternal and child health. Second, gender equality and delayed marriage, because a later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and improves maternal and child outcomes while women's educational attainment widens life options. Third, informed and voluntary family-size choice framed as capability rather than compliance. Fourth, awareness of the relationship between population, resources and services so that pressure on schooling, housing and health provision is understood rather than moralised. Then point out the measures, which is the second half of the directive and where most answers thin out. Deliver the content through school curricula at age-appropriate stages, through community outreach that reaches out-of-school adolescents, and through frontline health services so that information and access arrive together rather than separately. Locate the whole design inside the National Population Policy, 2000 frame of unmet contraceptive need, replacement-level fertility and long-term stabilisation aligned with sustainable development, and attach explicit anti-coercion safeguards so the programme cannot slide into target-setting. Qualify the recommendation honestly. Fertility in India is markedly uneven across states, so identical content will meet very different conditions, and the National Family Health Survey rounds are

survey estimates rather than Census stocks, so they may indicate direction without supplying a state-uniform target. Conclude that population education succeeds when it expands informed capability and fails the moment it becomes demographic instruction.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Demand: Audited ledger demand rendering: objectives of population education and the measures India needs. Discuss and point out, 15 marks, 250 words. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication.

Qualification: State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Define the subject precisely at the start: population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education about population processes and their social consequences, and it is not a persuasion campaign attached to a numerical target. Group the objectives so that the discuss half of the directive is visibly organised. First, reproductive and health information that allows informed decisions about marriage timing, spacing and maternal and child health. Second, gender equality and delayed marriage, because a later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and improves maternal and child outcomes while women's educational attainment widens life options. Third, informed and voluntary family-size choice framed as capability rather than compliance. Fourth, awareness of the relationship between population, resources and services so that pressure on schooling, housing and health provision is understood rather than moralised. Then point out the measures, which is the second half of the directive and where most answers thin out. Deliver the content through school curricula at age-appropriate stages, through community outreach that reaches out-of-school adolescents, and through frontline health services so that information and access arrive together rather than separately. Locate the whole design inside the National Population Policy, 2000 frame of unmet contraceptive need, replacement-level fertility and long-term stabilisation aligned with sustainable development, and attach explicit anti-coercion safeguards so the programme cannot slide into target-setting. Qualify the recommendation honestly. Fertility in India is markedly uneven across states, so identical content will meet very different conditions, and the National Family Health Survey rounds are survey estimates rather than Census stocks, so they may indicate direction without supplying a state-uniform target. Conclude that population education succeeds when it expands informed capability and fails the moment it becomes demographic instruction.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing the mechanism; define and state a thesis; organise five points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; compress examples before mechanisms and reserve the final minute for causation, group variation and legal-outcome limits.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains rather than lists, integrates India-centric evidence and avoids homogenisation, legalism and causal overclaim.

How to improve this answer: For "PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2021 GS-I Q18", replace the weakest generalisation with one named community, region, institution, movement or source-dated dataset and state what that evidence cannot establish.

PYQ DEMAND CARD 3 - 2024 GS-I Q7

Demand: What is the concept of a 'demographic winter'? Is the world moving towards such a situation? Elaborate. (Answer in 150 words) 10 marks.

Status: Wording confirmed in the locally held official 2024 General Studies Paper-I. The audited 2024-2025 Mains ledger routes this row to the Geography world-population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it; the conflict is recorded openly and this answer is written from the Indian Society social-demography spine without claiming the Geography model owner's material.

Model solution: Define first and define tightly: demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, with workforce shrinkage and old-age support

strain as its consequences. Immediately separate it from the demographic dividend, which describes the potentially growth-favourable window when the working-age share is largest; the two are near-opposite phases of the same transition and conflating them is the commonest error on this demand. Answer the second half as a graded process rather than a yes or no. Several populations are already inside the condition because fertility fell early and life expectancy continued rising, while other populations remain meaningfully above replacement, so the world is moving toward the condition unevenly rather than uniformly. Bring the Indian evidence with its status attached: the National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24 and released on 29 May 2026, reports a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1 and labels its results provisional, and the earlier round five figure of 2.0 for 2019-21 is a historical comparator; neither is a Census stock and neither describes any individual state. State the aggregation limit explicitly, because it is the analytical move the demand rewards: fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, so a near-replacement national figure simultaneously conceals states already below replacement, where ageing pressure and a rising old-age dependency ratio meet a still predominantly family-based support system, and states still above replacement retaining an open dividend window. Name the drivers common to both halves, namely women's education, later marriage, urbanisation and the rising direct and opportunity cost of children, and add second demographic transition theory only as a European-derived lens rather than an established Indian diagnosis. Conclude that demographic winter is a conditional, regionally graded risk rather than a settled global fact, and that the policy question is therefore about preparing differing regional age structures rather than about reversing a single number.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “PYQ DEMAND CARD 3 - 2024 GS-I Q7”, all clauses, a sociological mechanism, historical trajectory, intersectional and regional variation, named Indian evidence, constitutional/institutional boundaries and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Define first and define tightly: demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, with workforce shrinkage and old-age support strain as its consequences. Immediately separate it from the demographic dividend, which describes the potentially growth-favourable window when the working-age share is largest; the two are near-opposite phases of the same transition and conflating them is the commonest error on this demand. Answer the second half as a graded process rather than a yes or no. Several populations are already inside the condition because fertility fell early and life expectancy continued rising, while other populations remain meaningfully above replacement, so the world is moving toward the condition unevenly rather than uniformly. Bring the Indian evidence with its status attached: the National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24 and released on 29 May 2026, reports a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1 and labels its results provisional, and the earlier round five figure of 2.0 for 2019-21 is a historical comparator; neither is a Census stock and neither describes any individual state. State the aggregation limit explicitly, because it is the analytical move the demand rewards: fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, so a near-replacement national figure simultaneously conceals states already below replacement, where ageing pressure and a rising old-age dependency ratio meet a still predominantly family-based support system, and states still above replacement retaining an open dividend window. Name the drivers common to both halves, namely women's education, later marriage, urbanisation and the rising direct and opportunity cost of children, and add second demographic transition theory only as a European-derived lens rather than an established Indian diagnosis. Conclude that demographic winter is a conditional, regionally graded risk rather than a settled global fact, and that the policy question is therefore about preparing differing regional age structures rather than about reversing a single number.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Demand: What is the concept of a 'demographic winter'? Is the world moving towards such a situation? Elaborate. (Answer in 150 words) 10 marks. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication.

Qualification: State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Define first and define tightly: demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, with workforce shrinkage and old-age support strain as its consequences. Immediately separate it from the demographic dividend, which describes the potentially growth-favourable window when the working-age share is largest; the two are near-opposite phases of the same transition and conflating them is the commonest error on this demand. Answer the second half as a graded process rather than a yes or no. Several populations are already inside the condition because fertility fell early and life expectancy continued rising, while other populations remain meaningfully above replacement, so the world is moving toward the condition unevenly rather than uniformly. Bring the Indian evidence with its status attached: the National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24 and released on 29 May 2026, reports a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1 and labels its results provisional, and the earlier round five figure of 2.0 for 2019-21 is a historical comparator; neither is a Census stock and neither describes any individual state. State the aggregation limit explicitly, because it is the analytical move the demand rewards: fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, so a near-replacement national figure simultaneously conceals states already below replacement, where ageing pressure and a rising old-age dependency ratio meet a still predominantly family-based support system, and states still above replacement retaining an open dividend window. Name the drivers common to both halves, namely women's education, later marriage, urbanisation and the rising direct and opportunity cost of children, and add second demographic transition theory only as a European-derived lens rather than an established Indian diagnosis. Conclude that demographic winter is a conditional, regionally graded risk rather than a settled global fact, and that the policy question is therefore about preparing differing regional age structures rather than about reversing a single number.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing the mechanism; define and state a thesis; organise five points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; compress examples before mechanisms and reserve the final minute for causation, group variation and legal-outcome limits.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains rather than lists, integrates India-centric evidence and avoids homogenisation, legalism and causal overclaim.

How to improve this answer: For "PYQ DEMAND CARD 3 - 2024 GS-I Q7", replace the weakest generalisation with one named community, region, institution, movement or source-dated dataset and state what that evidence cannot establish.

ORIGINAL MAINS 1 - 10 MARKS

Question: Discuss the social determinants of fertility decline in India. Answer in about 150 words.

Model thesis: Fertility decline in India is produced by schooling, marriage timing, contraceptive access and the changing cost of children acting together, so the honest account names an interacting determinant set rather than promoting one factor to sole cause.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome.
- Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context.
- A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable.
- Urban residence raises both the direct cost of raising children through housing and schooling expenditure and the opportunity cost through foregone earnings, which is why urbanisation appears repeatedly in fertility explanations as an economic pressure operating through social decisions.

- Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing.

Qualified conclusion: Fertility decline in India is produced by schooling, marriage timing, contraceptive access and the changing cost of children acting together, so the honest account names an interacting determinant set rather than promoting one factor to sole cause.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on “Discuss the social determinants of fertility decline in India. Answer in about 150 words.”, all clauses, a sociological mechanism, historical trajectory, intersectional and regional variation, named Indian evidence, constitutional/institutional boundaries and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Fertility decline in India is produced by schooling, marriage timing, contraceptive access and the changing cost of children acting together, so the honest account names an interacting determinant set rather than promoting one factor to sole cause.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Urban residence raises both the direct cost of raising children through housing and schooling expenditure and the opportunity cost through foregone earnings, which is why urbanisation appears repeatedly in fertility explanations as an economic pressure operating through social decisions. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
5. **Claim and named evidence:** Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Fertility decline in India is produced by schooling, marriage timing, contraceptive access and the changing cost of children acting together, so the honest account names an interacting determinant set rather than promoting one factor to sole cause.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing the mechanism; define and state a thesis; organise three points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; compress examples before mechanisms and reserve the final minute for causation, group variation and legal-outcome limits.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains rather than lists, integrates India-centric evidence and avoids homogenisation, legalism and causal overclaim.

How to improve this answer: For “Discuss the social determinants of fertility decline in India. Answer in about 150 words.”, replace the weakest generalisation with one named community, region, institution, movement or source-dated dataset and state what that evidence cannot establish.

ORIGINAL MAINS 2 - 10 MARKS

Question: Distinguish demographic winter from the demographic dividend and state which one describes India. Answer in about 150 words.

Model thesis: The two terms name near-opposite phases of transition, and because Indian fertility is sharply uneven neither label describes the whole country, so the correct answer is a state-graded one supported by a dated survey anchor.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average.
- The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window.
- Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing.
- The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value.

Qualified conclusion: The two terms name near-opposite phases of transition, and because Indian fertility is sharply uneven neither label describes the whole country, so the correct answer is a state-graded one supported by a dated survey anchor.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “Distinguish demographic winter from the demographic dividend and state which one describes...”, all clauses, a sociological mechanism, historical trajectory, intersectional and regional variation, named Indian evidence, constitutional/institutional boundaries and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The two terms name near-opposite phases of transition, and because Indian fertility is sharply uneven neither label describes the whole country, so the correct answer is a state-graded one supported by a dated survey anchor.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation,

regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

2. **Claim and named evidence:** The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window.

Analysis: Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

3. **Claim and named evidence:** Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication.

Qualification: State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The two terms name near-opposite phases of transition, and because Indian fertility is sharply uneven neither label describes the whole country, so the correct answer is a state-graded one supported by a dated survey anchor.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing the mechanism; define and state a thesis; organise three points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; compress examples before mechanisms and reserve the final minute for causation, group variation and legal-outcome limits.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains rather than lists, integrates India-centric evidence and avoids homogenisation, legalism and causal overclaim.

How to improve this answer: For “Distinguish demographic winter from the demographic dividend and state which one describes...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one named community, region, institution, movement or source-dated dataset and state what that evidence cannot establish.

ORIGINAL MAINS 3 - 15 MARKS

Question: Examine the proposition that empowering women is the key to controlling population growth. Answer in about 250 words.

Model thesis: Women's education, later marriage, health information and economic voice expand informed and voluntary family-size choice, which is why empowerment outperforms control as a policy frame, though son preference and uneven service access qualify how far agency alone can carry the outcome.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context.
- A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable.
- Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has

reduced its overall desired family size.

- Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome.
- Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards.

Qualified conclusion: Women's education, later marriage, health information and economic voice expand informed and voluntary family-size choice, which is why empowerment outperforms control as a policy frame, though son preference and uneven service access qualify how far agency alone can carry the outcome.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on "Examine the proposition that empowering women is the key to controlling population growth....", all clauses, a sociological mechanism, historical trajectory, intersectional and regional variation, named Indian evidence, constitutional/institutional boundaries and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Women's education, later marriage, health information and economic voice expand informed and voluntary family-size choice, which is why empowerment outperforms control as a policy frame, though son preference and uneven service access qualify how far agency alone can carry the outcome.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its overall desired family size. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
5. **Claim and named evidence:** Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources,

delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Women's education, later marriage, health information and economic voice expand informed and voluntary family-size choice, which is why empowerment outperforms control as a policy frame, though son preference and uneven service access qualify how far agency alone can carry the outcome.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing the mechanism; define and state a thesis; organise five points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; compress examples before mechanisms and reserve the final minute for causation, group variation and legal-outcome limits.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains rather than lists, integrates India-centric evidence and avoids homogenisation, legalism and causal overclaim.

How to improve this answer: For "Examine the proposition that empowering women is the key to controlling population growth...", replace the weakest generalisation with one named community, region, institution, movement or source-dated dataset and state what that evidence cannot establish.

ORIGINAL MAINS 4 - 15 MARKS

Question: Examine why a national fertility aggregate can mask sharp sub-national demographic divergence in India. Answer in about 250 words.

Model thesis: A national average is a weighted summary of states in different transition phases, so it simultaneously conceals localised ageing pressure and continuing high-fertility conditions, and any policy inference drawn from the aggregate alone is therefore unsafe.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing.
- The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value.
- The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet.
- A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation.
- The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window.

Qualified conclusion: A national average is a weighted summary of states in different transition phases, so it simultaneously conceals localised ageing pressure and continuing high-fertility conditions, and any policy inference drawn from the aggregate alone is therefore unsafe.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on "Examine why a national fertility aggregate can mask sharp sub-national demographic divergence...", all clauses, a sociological mechanism, historical trajectory,

intersectional and regional variation, named Indian evidence, constitutional/institutional boundaries and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: A national average is a weighted summary of states in different transition phases, so it simultaneously conceals localised ageing pressure and continuing high-fertility conditions, and any policy inference drawn from the aggregate alone is therefore unsafe.

Analytical body:

- 1. Claim and named evidence:** Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
- 2. Claim and named evidence:** The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
- 3. Claim and named evidence:** The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of 1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
- 4. Claim and named evidence:** A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
- 5. Claim and named evidence:** The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: A national average is a weighted summary of states in different transition phases, so it simultaneously conceals localised ageing pressure and continuing high-fertility conditions, and any policy inference drawn from the aggregate alone is therefore unsafe.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing the mechanism; define and state a thesis; organise five points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; compress examples before mechanisms and reserve the final minute for causation, group variation and legal-outcome limits.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains rather than lists, integrates India-centric evidence and avoids homogenisation, legalism and causal overclaim.

How to improve this answer: For “Examine why a national fertility aggregate can mask sharp sub-national demographic divergence...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one named community, region, institution, movement or source-dated dataset and state what that evidence cannot establish.

ORIGINAL MAINS 5 - 20 MARKS

Question: Assess the social implications of India's transition toward an ageing population structure. Answer in about 300 words.

Model thesis: Ageing is the success of an earlier health and fertility transition arriving as a care, workforce and security problem, and its severity depends on how fast formal support has been built where fertility fell earliest rather than on the national age structure.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- Population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age support and workforce-composition challenges, so a competent answer holds both framings together instead of choosing one.
- A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing.
- The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state.
- Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it.
- Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing.

Qualified conclusion: Ageing is the success of an earlier health and fertility transition arriving as a care, workforce and security problem, and its severity depends on how fast formal support has been built where fertility fell earliest rather than on the national age structure.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on “Assess the social implications of India's transition toward an ageing population structure....”, all clauses, a sociological mechanism, historical trajectory, intersectional and regional variation, named Indian evidence, constitutional/institutional boundaries and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Ageing is the success of an earlier health and fertility transition arriving as a care, workforce and security problem, and its severity depends on how fast formal support has been built where fertility fell earliest rather than on the national age structure.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age support and workforce-composition challenges, so a competent answer holds both framings together instead of choosing one. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated

social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

3. **Claim and named evidence:** The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
5. **Claim and named evidence:** Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Ageing is the success of an earlier health and fertility transition arriving as a care, workforce and security problem, and its severity depends on how fast formal support has been built where fertility fell earliest rather than on the national age structure.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing the mechanism; define and state a thesis; organise six to eight points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; compress examples before mechanisms and reserve the final minute for causation, group variation and legal-outcome limits.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains rather than lists, integrates India-centric evidence and avoids homogenisation, legalism and causal overclaim.

How to improve this answer: For "Assess the social implications of India's transition toward an ageing population structure....", replace the weakest generalisation with one named community, region, institution, movement or source-dated dataset and state what that evidence cannot establish.

ORIGINAL MAINS 6 - 20 MARKS

Question: Discuss the objectives of population education and point out the measures India needs to adopt. Answer in about 300 words.

Model thesis: Population education earns its place when it builds informed voluntary capability about health, gender equality, marriage timing and resource pressure, and it fails the moment it is converted into a demographic-target campaign that coerces rather than informs.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards.

- The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target.
- Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome.
- Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context.
- A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation.

Qualified conclusion: Population education earns its place when it builds informed voluntary capability about health, gender equality, marriage timing and resource pressure, and it fails the moment it is converted into a demographic-target campaign that coerces rather than informs.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on “Discuss the objectives of population education and point out the measures India needs to...”, all clauses, a sociological mechanism, historical trajectory, intersectional and regional variation, named Indian evidence, constitutional/institutional boundaries and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Population education earns its place when it builds informed voluntary capability about health, gender equality, marriage timing and resource pressure, and it fails the moment it is converted into a demographic-target campaign that coerces rather than informs.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in

fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

5. **Claim and named evidence:** A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Population education earns its place when it builds informed voluntary capability about health, gender equality, marriage timing and resource pressure, and it fails the moment it is converted into a demographic-target campaign that coerces rather than informs.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing the mechanism; define and state a thesis; organise six to eight points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; compress examples before mechanisms and reserve the final minute for causation, group variation and legal-outcome limits.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains rather than lists, integrates India-centric evidence and avoids homogenisation, legalism and causal overclaim.

How to improve this answer: For “Discuss the objectives of population education and point out the measures India needs to...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one named community, region, institution, movement or source-dated dataset and state what that evidence cannot establish.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Subject: Indian Society | **Tier:** Advanced | **GS Paper:** GS-I. **Core area:** The demographic-winter causal chain, second-demographic-transition theory, ageing-society trade-offs, and boundary cases across India's uneven fertility transition. **Grounded in:** National Population Policy 2000; NFHS-5 (2019-21; historical comparator; NFHS-6 was released 29 May 2026); audited 2024 GS-I Mains PYQ. **FACT:** = source-grounded | **ANALYSIS:** = inference/analysis | **CURRENT:** = current anchor. *Companion:* basic/06_Population-and-Associated-Issues.md.

Data-status correction (13 August 2026): NFHS-6 (2023-24) was released on 29 May 2026. NFHS-5 (2019-21) values below are historical comparators, not the latest national NFHS result. Do not quote an NFHS-6 metric unless taken directly from its released national fact sheet; neither NFHS round is a Census stock or by itself proof of causation.

1. Architecture

SOCIAL DETERMINANTS

women's education, marriage age,
urbanisation, rising child-rearing cost,
contraceptive access

|

v

FERTILITY DECLINE (uneven across states)

|

-----+

|

v

STATES NEAR/BELOW
REPLACEMENT LEVEL

|

v

AGEING PRESSURE
+ WORKFORCE SHRINKAGE
RISK ("demographic
winter" localised)

|

+-----+

|

v

NATIONAL AGGREGATE PICTURE:

dated national TFR (NFHS-5, 2019-21: 2.0)

masks strong sub-national divergence

|

v

STATES ABOVE
REPLACEMENT LEVEL

|

v

CONTINUED YOUNG
AGE STRUCTURE
(dividend window
still open)

|

Analytical claim: ANALYSIS: The 2024 GS-I PYQ's "demographic winter" question cannot be answered correctly at the national aggregate level alone - India's national TFR of 2.0 (NFHS-5, 2019-21) sits near replacement, but this masks a sharp sub-national divergence between states already experiencing ageing-linked demographic-winter pressure and states still within their demographic-dividend window; the correct analytical move is to treat "is the world moving towards demographic winter" as a graded, regionally uneven process rather than a single global yes/no fact.

2. Concepts and distinctions

Concept	Precise meaning
FACT: Demographic winter vs demographic dividend	Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility with population ageing and eventual decline; demographic dividend describes a potentially growth-favourable working-age share. They are distinct frameworks, but a large country can show ageing pressure and dividend potential across different regions or groups at the same time.
ANALYSIS: First versus second demographic transition	The first demographic transition describes mortality and fertility decline; "second demographic transition" theory links further sub-replacement fertility to value and family-formation shifts. It is a framework developed largely from European experience, not a sufficient diagnosis of every Indian state.
ANALYSIS: National aggregate vs sub-national divergence	India's national TFR figures mask states already at or below replacement (raising ageing concerns locally) alongside states still meaningfully above replacement (retaining a longer dividend window) - policy and analysis must be state-disaggregated, not nation-uniform.
ANALYSIS: Ageing as burden vs ageing as achievement	Population ageing reflects successful mortality and fertility transition (an achievement of health and social policy) but simultaneously creates old-age-support and workforce-composition challenges (a burden) - both framings are valid and should be balanced in an answer.
ANALYSIS: Son preference vs sex ratio at birth as outcome	Son preference is the underlying social attitude; skewed sex ratio at birth is its measurable demographic outcome - conflating the two in an answer loses the causal distinction between attitude and metric.

3. Detailed causal chain

Fertility-decline chain

1. Rising women's educational attainment delays marriage and raises awareness/use of contraception.
2. Urbanisation raises the direct and opportunity cost of raising children (housing, school fees, foregone income).
3. ANALYSIS: These pressures interact with, rather than replace, persistent son preference in some regions, where families may continue childbearing until a son is born even as overall family-size norms shrink.
4. National TFR approached replacement level in NFHS-5 (2019-21: 2.0) as an aggregate outcome of these state-varying processes.

Demographic-winter-risk chain (state-level)

1. In early-transition, fast-fertility-decline states, TFR falls below replacement while life expectancy continues rising.
2. ANALYSIS: The working-age population share peaks and then begins to shrink relative to the elderly population.
3. ANALYSIS: Old-age dependency ratio rises, straining family-based support systems and underdeveloped formal old-age social-security coverage.
4. ANALYSIS: Absent labour-productivity gains or migration inflows, workforce shrinkage can begin to constrain regional economic growth - the localised "demographic winter" condition.

Ageing-society response chain

1. ANALYSIS: Family-based old-age support remains India's dominant model but is weakening as nuclear-family structures (Topic 04) reduce co-resident caregiving capacity.
2. ANALYSIS: Formal old-age social-security and healthcare systems (Social-Justice's territory) are, in most states, not yet scaled to the pace of ageing.
3. ANALYSIS: A policy response gap therefore exists between the speed of demographic ageing in early-transition states and the readiness of formal support systems.

4. Institutional and reform architecture

- FACT: **National Population Policy, 2000 (cross-linked, not restated in mechanism form):** its tiered objectives cover unmet need, replacement fertility and long-term stabilisation. When assessing ageing, ask whether particular services and state policies meet local need; do not infer a national policy gap merely from a dated TFR.
- ANALYSIS: **State-specific variation:** age structure, fertility and elder-care capacity vary substantially across states. A valid answer diagnoses the relevant state/region rather than attributing every local concern to a single national policy design.

5. Indian applications and boundary cases

- ANALYSIS: **Boundary case 1 - localised demographic winter:** a state with TFR meaningfully below replacement and a rising elderly-dependency ratio shows the demographic-winter condition already present sub-nationally, even while the national aggregate (TFR 2.0) suggests only borderline replacement.
- ANALYSIS: **Boundary case 2 - continued dividend window:** a state with TFR still above replacement and a young, growing working-age population shows the opposite condition coexisting within the same country.
- ANALYSIS: **Boundary case 3 - son-preference persistence amid falling family size:** a household that has reduced its overall desired family size but continues childbearing until a son is born shows social determinants (family-size norms) and son preference operating simultaneously rather than one simply replacing the

other.

6. Limitations and trade-offs

- ANALYSIS: **Aggregate-versus-disaggregated-analysis trade-off:** citing only the national TFR (2.0) to answer whether "the world" or "India" is moving toward demographic winter understates the sharper reality in early-transition states - a key analytical limitation the 2024 PYQ rewards students for addressing.
- ANALYSIS: **Policy-lag trade-off:** National Population Policy 2000's high-fertility-era framing has not been matched by an equivalent low-fertility/ageing-era policy architecture, creating a readiness gap precisely where the demographic-winter risk is emerging fastest.
- ANALYSIS: **Migration-as-offset trade-off:** using internal migration to offset regional workforce shrinkage helps the receiving region's economy but can strain the sending region's own ageing-support capacity if working-age adults leave elderly parents behind.

7. Must-Know Facts for Advanced Prelims

- FACT: NFHS-5 (2019-21) recorded India's national TFR at 2.0, near replacement level. It is the historical national NFHS round; NFHS-6 (2023-24) was released 29 May 2026.
- FACT: National Population Policy, 2000 set immediate (unmet contraceptive need), medium-term (replacement-level TFR) and long-term (stable population by around 2045, aligned with sustainable development) objectives.
- ANALYSIS: Sub-national fertility variation in India is substantial: several states are already at or below replacement level while others remain meaningfully above it.
- ANALYSIS: "Second demographic transition" theory is an analytical lens for value-linked sub-replacement fertility, not a universal causal account.
- ANALYSIS: Demographic winter and demographic dividend are distinct frameworks; sub-national differences mean they need not describe every part of a large country in the same way.

8. Advanced Prelims traps

- WRONG: India's national TFR of 2.0 means no Indian state faces demographic-winter risk. -> The national figure masks states already below replacement facing localised ageing and workforce-shrinkage pressure.
- WRONG: A national average proves every state is in the same demographic phase. -> A large country can have ageing pressure in some states or groups and dividend potential in others; specify geography, indicator and time period.
- WRONG: National Population Policy, 2000 alone answers every ageing or low-fertility question. -> Its stated objectives must be distinguished from contemporary state-specific service, care and labour-market needs; evaluate the relevant intervention rather than asserting a blanket policy verdict.
- WRONG: Son preference disappears once overall desired family size falls. -> Families can reduce desired family size while still continuing childbearing specifically until a son is born, showing the two dynamics can coexist.

9. CURRENT: Current-anchor note

- CURRENT: NFHS-6 (2023-24) national fact sheets report a total TFR of **2.0** (urban 1.6, rural 2.1). The results are provisional survey estimates that mask sub-national variation; do not treat them as a uniform current state figure.

10. PYQ-based analytical application

- FACT: **2024 GS-I (10 marks, verbatim):** "What is the concept of a 'demographic winter'? Is the world moving towards such a situation? Elaborate." Analytical route: (a) define demographic winter precisely as sustained sub-replacement fertility with ageing and eventual decline; (b) cite the dated NFHS-5 national TFR of 2.0 as the Indian anchor while explicitly flagging sub-national divergence; (c) note several developed countries are already

well into demographic-winter conditions; (d) conclude the world is moving toward this situation unevenly - some regions already there, others (with continued high fertility) still distant - driven by the same social determinants that explain ordinary fertility decline.

11. Mains-ready framework

Central thesis: Whether "the world" or India is moving toward demographic winter cannot be answered as a single yes/no fact; it must be assessed as an uneven, state/region-graded process in which some populations are already experiencing ageing-linked workforce pressure while others retain an open demographic-dividend window, with the same social determinants (education, marriage age, urbanisation) driving fertility decline in both directions of this spectrum.

1. Define demographic winter precisely and distinguish it from demographic dividend.
2. State the dated national anchor figure (NFHS-5, 2019-21 TFR 2.0) and immediately flag its aggregate-masking limitation.
3. Give one region/state-level example each of demographic-winter risk and continued dividend-window conditions.
4. Apply the first-versus-second-demographic-transition distinction to explain below-replacement decline beyond material necessity.
5. Diagnose the relevant state-level service, care and labour-market response rather than assuming a single national policy-lag.
6. Note the migration-as-offset trade-off between receiving and sending regions.
7. Distinguish son preference (attitude) from sex ratio at birth (outcome) if relevant.
8. Conclude with a graded, not uniform, assessment of the demographic-winter proposition.

12. Probable questions

- ANALYSIS: **Prelims:** What condition describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual decline?
- FACT: **Mains (10 marks, 2024 GS-I PYQ, verbatim):** What is the concept of a 'demographic winter'? Is the world moving towards such a situation? Elaborate.
- ANALYSIS: **Mains (15 marks):** Examine why India's national fertility aggregate can mask sharp sub-national demographic divergence.
- ANALYSIS: **Mains (10 marks):** Distinguish between the "first" and "second" demographic transition as explanations for below-replacement fertility.

13. Study links

- FACT: Foundation companion: [basic/06_Population-and-Associated-Issues.md](#).
- FACT: Geography/basic/26_World-Population-and-Demographic-Transition.md - full Demographic Transition Model and dividend theory (do not re-derive here).
- FACT: Social-Justice/basic/12_Elderly-and-Senior-Citizens.md - old-age social-security law and schemes.
- FACT: advanced/04_Family-Marriage-and-Kinship.md - nuclearisation's effect on family-based elder care.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: [_PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md](#).

- **Years represented:** 2019, 2021
- **Paper(s):** GS-I

- Routed question demands: 2

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2019	GS-I	9	Empowering women as key to controlling population growth	Discuss · 10 marks · 150 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2021	GS-I	18	Objectives of population education and measures for India	Discuss and point out · 15 marks · 250 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.

What this owner must now support

- Empowering women as key to controlling population growth
- Objectives of population education and measures for India

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

Population and Associated Issues: RAPID CONCEPT AND EVIDENCE MAP

- Population as a social question:** Population change is treated in this owner as a social process shaped by schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference, health services and contraceptive access, while the stage-based demographic transition model and dividend theory remain the property of Geography and are cross-linked rather than re-derived.
- Social determinants of fertility:** Social determinants of fertility are the non-biological factors that shape childbearing decisions, namely women's educational attainment, age at marriage, employment, desired family size, contraceptive access and son preference, and their joint operation means no single determinant may be advanced as the sole cause of a fertility outcome.
- Women's education pathway:** Women's educational attainment is associated with later marriage, wider knowledge and use of contraception and a broader set of life options, which makes it the central social pathway in fertility transition, though its effect operates in interaction with service access, household income, prevailing norms and state context.
- Age at marriage:** A later age at marriage compresses the reproductive window and is associated with better maternal and child health outcomes, which makes marriage timing a social lever that works alongside contraceptive access rather than a purely legal or medical variable.
- Son preference as an attitude:** Son preference is a social preference for male children linked historically to inheritance rules, old-age support expectations and patrilineal family structure, and because it is attitudinal it can persist even after a household has reduced its overall desired family size.
- Sex ratio at birth as an outcome:** The sex ratio at birth is the measurable demographic outcome through which son preference becomes visible in parts of India, so the attitude and the metric must be named separately and the legal-regulatory response to sex selection remains a Social Justice and Polity matter.
- National Population Policy, 2000:** The National Population Policy, 2000 of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare set an immediate objective of addressing unmet contraceptive need, a medium-term objective of bringing the Total Fertility Rate to replacement level and a long-term objective of a stable population by around 2045 aligned with sustainable development, and it is a rights-based tiered policy rather than a coercive numerical target.
- NFHS-5 as a historical comparator:** The National Family Health Survey round five, covering 2019-21, reported an all-India Total Fertility Rate of 2.0, and after the release of the sixth round this figure functions as a dated historical comparator that shows direction rather than a current-year or state-uniform value.
- NFHS-6 release and provisional status:** The National Family Health Survey round six, covering 2023-24, was released on 29 May 2026 and its national fact sheets report a total Total Fertility Rate of 2.0 with an urban value of

1.6 and a rural value of 2.1, and because the fact sheets label the results provisional no metric may be quoted unless it is taken directly from that released national fact sheet.

10. **Survey is not a census stock:** A National Family Health Survey estimate, a Census stock and an administrative registration figure are three different kinds of evidence, so a survey average must never be presented as a completed enumeration, as a current-year state figure or by itself as proof of causation.
11. **Sub-national divergence:** Fertility decline in India is markedly uneven, with several states already at or below replacement level while parts of central and eastern India remain meaningfully above it, so a national aggregate masks the divergence that population questions are usually testing.
12. **Demographic winter:** Demographic winter describes sustained sub-replacement fertility combined with population ageing and eventual population decline, raising concerns about workforce shrinkage and old-age support, and it is a conditional population pattern rather than a label that can be attached to a whole country from one national average.
13. **Demographic dividend contrast:** The demographic dividend describes the potentially growth-favourable window in which the working-age share is largest, so it and demographic winter are near-opposite phases of transition, and a large country can show ageing pressure in some states while other states retain an open dividend window.
14. **Ageing as achievement and burden:** Population ageing simultaneously reflects the success of mortality and fertility transition and creates old-age support and workforce-composition challenges, so a competent answer holds both framings together instead of choosing one.
15. **Old-age dependency and family support:** A rising old-age dependency ratio strains a support system that in India is still predominantly family-based, and nuclearisation reduces co-resident caregiving capacity while formal old-age social security, whose scheme detail belongs to Social Justice, is in most states not yet scaled to the pace of ageing.
16. **First and second demographic transition:** The first demographic transition describes mortality decline followed by fertility decline, while second demographic transition theory links further sub-replacement fertility to shifts in values and family formation, and the second framework was developed largely from European experience and is an analytical lens rather than a sufficient diagnosis of any Indian state.
17. **Urbanisation and the cost of children:** Urban residence raises both the direct cost of raising children through housing and schooling expenditure and the opportunity cost through foregone earnings, which is why urbanisation appears repeatedly in fertility explanations as an economic pressure operating through social decisions.
18. **Migration as an offset:** Internal migration can offset workforce shrinkage in a receiving region while straining the sending region's own ageing-support capacity when working-age adults leave elderly parents behind, so migration is a redistribution of the ageing problem rather than a national solution to it.
19. **Population education:** Population education is age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting education whose objectives group under reproductive and health information, gender equality and delayed marriage, informed and voluntary family-size choice, and awareness of the relationship between population and resources, delivered through schools, community outreach and health services within the National Population Policy, 2000 frame and with explicit anti-coercion safeguards.
20. **Verified direct Mains demands:** Three direct General Studies Paper-I demands are carried by this owner: the 2019 demand on empowering women in relation to population growth worth 10 marks and the 2021 demand on the objectives of population education and the measures India needs worth 15 marks, both routed in the audited 2018-2023 ledger to the Advanced owner with the Core owner recording that Core routing supersedes, and the 2024 demographic-winter demand worth 10 marks whose ledger route names the Geography population owner while this owner's own answer-architecture table claims it.

Population and Associated Issues: CLOSE-OPTION AND CAUSAL TRAPS

- Do not answer a population question with a recital of the demographic transition model owned by Geography.
- Do not treat demographic winter and demographic dividend as the same phenomenon.
- Do not present a National Family Health Survey average as a Census stock or a current-year state figure.
- Do not quote a National Family Health Survey round six metric that is not taken from its released national fact sheet.
- Do not describe the National Population Policy, 2000 as a coercive one-child or two-child mandate.
- Do not treat son preference as a purely legal problem solved by anti-sex-selection law alone.
- Do not merge son preference as an attitude with the sex ratio at birth as a measured outcome.
- Do not assume that a falling desired family size automatically removes son preference.
- Do not use a single national Total Fertility Rate to describe every state's demographic phase.
- Do not invent a state fertility value, an elderly-population share or a dependency-ratio figure.
- Do not treat ageing only as a burden or only as an achievement.
- Do not apply second demographic transition theory to an Indian state as if it were an established diagnosis.
- Do not present internal migration as a costless national remedy for workforce shrinkage.
- Do not turn population education into a demographic-target campaign rather than informed voluntary capability.

Population and Associated Issues: ANSWER-WRITING SPINE

DEFINE THE SOCIAL UNIT -> STATE THE BOUNDARY RULE AND WHO IS INCLUDED
-> GROUP NAMED EVIDENCE BY MECHANISM OF REPRODUCTION OR CHANGE
-> TEST COUNTER-CASES, REGIONAL VARIATION AND CATEGORY LIMITS
-> SEPARATE CORRELATION FROM CAUSATION AND LAW FROM SOCIAL ACCEPTANCE
-> CLOSE WITH A GRADED, POLICY-AWARE VERDICT AND A DATA CAVEAT

Population and Associated Issues: CURRENT-LINK AND DATA BOUNDARY

No additional live official item was verified for this topic on 2026-09-02. Only the dated official anchors already carried by the repository owners are used, each with its issuing body and date. The package invents no caste, tribe, demographic or agrarian statistic, no legal or constitutional claim and no policy status.

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 1/12: Population as a social process

ENTRY -> schooling, marriage timing, desired family size, son preference
SERVICES -> contraceptive access and maternal and child health provision
EXCLUDED -> stage-based transition model and dividend theory owned by Geography
OUTPUT -> a social explanation, not a model recital
MUST REMEMBER: Population analysis separates size, growth, fertility, mortality, age structure, sex composition, density, distribution, migration and human capability; demographic transition and dividend are conditional processes shaped by health, education, gender agency and employment.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 2/12: Determinant interaction

EDUCATION -> later marriage plus contraceptive knowledge and wider options
MARRIAGE TIMING -> compressed reproductive window, better maternal outcomes
COST OF CHILDREN -> urban housing, schooling and foregone earnings
RULE -> determinants interact; no single factor is the sole cause

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 3/12: Attitude and metric

SON PREFERENCE -> attitude rooted in inheritance and old-age expectations
SEX RATIO AT BIRTH -> the measurable demographic outcome
COEXISTENCE -> smaller desired family size with continued son-seeking
OWNERSHIP -> sex-selection law belongs to Social Justice and Polity

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 4/12: Policy card

DOCUMENT -> National Population Policy, 2000, Ministry of Health and Family Welfare
IMMEDIATE -> address unmet contraceptive need
MEDIUM TERM -> bring Total Fertility Rate to replacement level
LONG TERM -> stable population by around 2045 with sustainable development

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 5/12: Evidence-status ladder

NFHS-6 -> released 29 May 2026, total 2.0, urban 1.6, rural 2.1, provisional
NFHS-5 -> 2019-21 round, Total Fertility Rate 2.0, historical comparator
CENSUS -> 2011 is the last completed full count; Census 2027 is prospective
PROHIBITION -> no survey average may be quoted as a state or current stock

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 6/12: Aggregate against divergence

NATIONAL -> a weighted summary of states in different transition phases
BELOW REPLACEMENT -> ageing pressure and workforce-shrinkage risk
ABOVE REPLACEMENT -> young structure with an open dividend window
VERDICT -> the honest answer is state-graded, not nation-uniform

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 7/12: Winter and dividend

DEMOGRAPHIC WINTER -> sustained sub-replacement fertility with ageing and decline
DEMOGRAPHIC DIVIDEND -> largest working-age share, growth-favourable window
RELATION -> near-opposite phases of the same transition
CAUTION -> a large country can display both across its regions

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 8/12: Ageing double reading

ACHIEVEMENT -> longer life from successful mortality and health transition
BURDEN -> rising old-age dependency and workforce recomposition
SUPPORT -> family-based care weakened by nuclearisation
GAP -> formal old-age security not yet scaled where fertility fell earliest

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 9/12: Two transition frameworks

FIRST TRANSITION -> mortality decline followed by fertility decline
SECOND TRANSITION -> value and family-formation shift below replacement
ORIGIN -> the second framework is largely European in derivation
STATUS -> an analytical lens, never an established Indian diagnosis

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 10/12: Migration offset

RECEIVING REGION -> working-age inflow cushions workforce shrinkage
SENDING REGION -> elderly parents left with thinner household support
NET EFFECT -> the ageing problem is redistributed, not removed
ANSWER USE -> state the regional trade-off before recommending mobility
CLOSE DISTINCTION: Population growth is not fertility, replacement fertility is not zero
growth, density is not pressure, sex ratio at birth is not overall sex ratio, Census stock
is not survey flow, and demographic dividend is an opportunity rather than an automatic
bonus.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 11/12: Population education design

CONTENT -> age-appropriate, scientific and rights-respecting instruction
OBJECTIVES -> health information, gender equality, voluntary choice, resource awareness
DELIVERY -> schools, community outreach and health services
SAFEGUARD -> capability building, never a demographic target
EVIDENCE LIMIT: Census 2011 is the latest completed census baseline as of review, while SRS,
NFHS-5 and projections have different dates and methods; compare Kerala/Tamil Nadu ageing,
EAG-state youth and migration destinations without causal claims from state averages alone.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 12/12: Population answer spine

OPEN -> define the term precisely and name the social mechanism
BODY -> dated anchor, then immediate disaggregation by state
TEST -> ageing pressure against continuing dividend conditions
CLOSE -> graded verdict with the survey-versus-census caveat